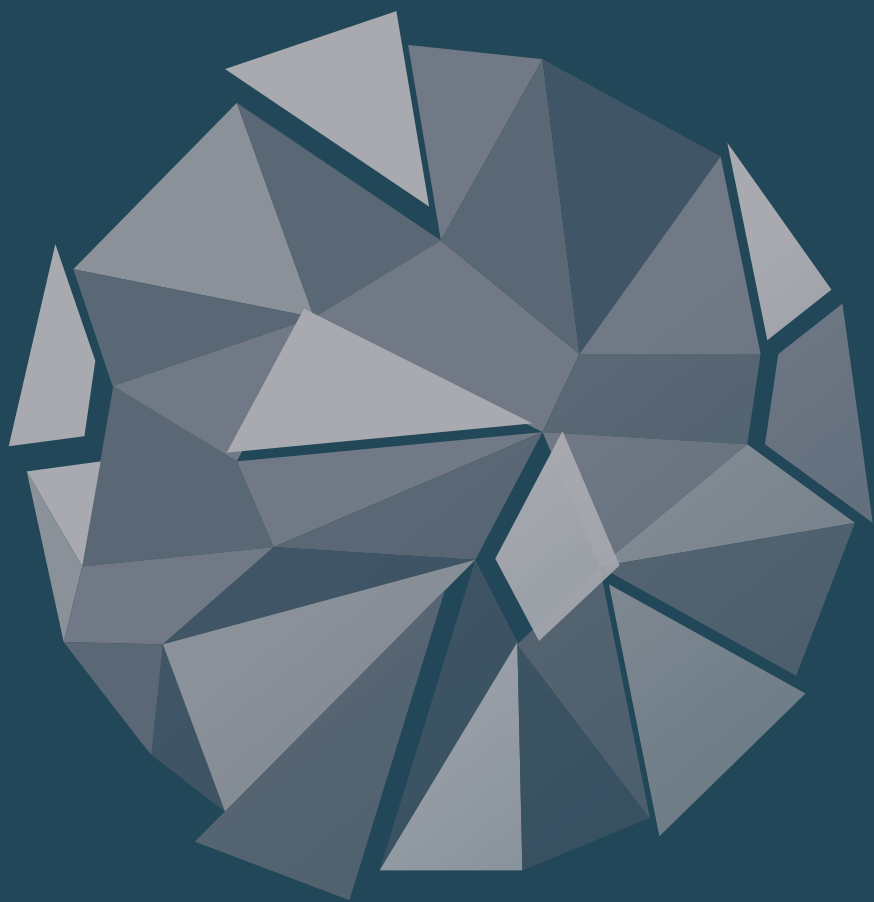


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As an open-access and peer-reviewed journal available in both print and online formats, *Global Geopolitics* is dedicated to disseminating high-quality research widely, reflecting its mission to redefine the study of geopolitics through a globally inclusive lens. By bridging traditional and non-traditional approaches beyond disciplinary boundaries, the journal highlights global connectivity and cooperation alongside conflicts and rivalries, encouraging innovative scholarship that deepens our understanding of international relations, power dynamics, and pressing global challenges. *Global Geopolitics* is owned and operated by Global Geopolitics Ltd.

Address: 124 City Road, London, United Kingdom, EC1V 2NX.

Tel: +44 7760 589688.

Email: editor@globalgeopoliticsjournal.com.

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Aims and Scope

In recent times, geopolitics has gained renewed significance, driven by the intensification of geostrategic rivalries and a surge in conflicts arising from non-traditional security concerns. This journal aims to address these contemporary challenges by offering a platform for a more globally-oriented perspective.

Global Geopolitics is not just about rehashing established geopolitical narratives; rather, it seeks to supplement them with fresh viewpoints and interdisciplinary approaches. We invite a diverse array of contributions from scholars, practitioners, policymakers, and activists. These contributions are pivotal in transcending traditional boundaries, offering insights that reflect the interconnected nature of global challenges and the necessity for collaborative solutions.

“Global Geopolitics” as a journal title encapsulates our dedication to redefining the study of geopolitics in a way that is inclusive, forward-looking, and reflective of the complex tapestry of global interactions in the modern world. It signals our aim to be at the forefront of academic discourse, where diverse global voices converge to shape a more nuanced understanding of international relations and global affairs. Most importantly, the inclusion of “Global” before “Geopolitics” intentionally shifts the focus from the traditional confines of geopolitical analysis, which often centers on geostrategic rivalries, conflicts, and wars. Instead, it emphasizes a broader, more interconnected perspective. Relatedly, the term “Global” symbolizes our commitment to transcending regional and national boundaries in our approach. It reflects our ambition to incorporate and mobilize the rich intellectual legacies and accumulated knowledge from various countries across all seven continents. This global approach is vital in fostering a diverse, inclusive, and comprehensive understanding of geopolitical dynamics, offering insights that are informed by a multitude of perspectives and experiences.

While acknowledging the enduring significance of traditional geopolitical challenges, such as territorial disputes, power dynamics, and diplomatic relations, *Global Geopolitics* endeavors to broaden the scope of analysis by integrating non-traditional

issues and multidisciplinary/interdisciplinary approaches invested in studying competition, rivalry, and cooperation among states and non-state actors by reference to their geographical features. Therefore, we also address a range of pressing global issues such as transnational crime, the repercussions of the Great Recession, the escalating challenges of climate change, and the global migrant crisis.

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Editorial

SECURITY, CONFLICT, AND THE LIMITS OF INTERNATIONAL ORDER

Efe Can Gürcan

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Security is rarely only about the balance of military capabilities. It is also about the rules through which states coexist, the alliances and institutions they construct, the technologies they permit themselves to use, and the boundaries they draw between sovereignty and international responsibility. Periods of geopolitical change make these connections particularly visible. Established arrangements become less reliable, new alignments emerge before their consequences are fully apparent, and technological or political developments raise questions for which existing institutions do not always provide ready answers.

The third issue of *Global Geopolitics* approaches security in this broader sense. Its five articles move across different periods and geographical settings, from the architecture of Eurasian security and the strategic landscape of the Eastern Mediterranean to autonomous weapons and the international politics of the Nigerian Civil War. They do not offer a single account of contemporary geopolitics. What connects them instead is a concern with the limits of existing arrangements: the limits of security architectures in accommodating shifts in power, of alliances in reconciling divergent interests, of international law in responding to new military tech-

nologies, and of international institutions when humanitarian claims encounter sovereignty and geopolitical interests.

Richard Sakwa's "Between Comity and Conflict: Revisiting Eurasian Security in the Multipolar Era" begins from a fundamental problem: how can security be organized across a politically plural Eurasia without reproducing either hegemonic tutelage or competing blocs? His answer emerges from a genealogy extending from the unrealized Volga Charter and the Yalta-Potsdam moment to the UN Charter International System and the later consolidation of the "Political West." Sakwa locates the roots of contemporary insecurity in a persistent gap between competing conceptions of European and Eurasian order. Against this background, he develops the idea of heterarchical comity, grounded in Charter pluralism, as an alternative basis for coexistence among states that need not share the same political model or geopolitical orientation.

Li Zhengdong examines the Eurasian security problem from a different direction in "Multipolarity and the Geopolitical Reorganization of the Eurasian Security Order." Drawing on Brzezinski's realist framework, Li argues that the redistribution of power across Eurasia is producing fragmentation rather than equilibrium. Strains within the transatlantic alliance, unresolved debates over European strategic autonomy, divergent threat perceptions within Europe, and Russia's declining influence in parts of the Caucasus and Central Asia are creating overlapping areas of competition and uncertainty. His description of Eurasia as a developing "strategic collision belt" captures a central paradox: a more dispersed distribution of power can widen the room for strategic maneuver while simultaneously making regional security less predictable.

Questions of alignment and strategic maneuver are also central to Sina Kısacık and Erinc Bayri's "The United States in the Eastern Mediterranean: Strategic Landscape Analysis of Energy Diplomacy, Security Politics, and Alignment Shifts." The Eastern Mediterranean provides a particularly revealing setting because energy routes, maritime disputes, military partnerships, and great-power competition intersect within a relatively concentrated geographical space. Kısacık and Bayri trace how U.S. engagement since the 2000s

has helped reshape this landscape through security partnerships, legislation, and calibrated military involvement. At the same time, Washington's closer relations with Greece, the Republic of Cyprus, Israel, and Egypt have coincided with growing tensions with Türkiye. The result is a regional configuration in which local disputes and alliances have become increasingly entangled with U.S. efforts to contain Russian influence and limit China's infrastructural and technological reach.

If the first three articles are principally concerned with the organization of geopolitical space and security relations, Jan Falgueras-Riu's "Regulating the Absurd: 'Killer Robots' and the Morality Behind Arms Regulations" turns to the boundaries of permissible violence in international security. Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems present an unusual regulatory problem because the question is not exhausted by whether a weapon can comply with existing international humanitarian law. Falgueras-Riu asks what happens when lethal decision-making itself becomes increasingly detached from immediate human agency. Distinguishing among established IHL concerns, ethical problems specific to autonomous force, and risks shared with other unmanned weapons, he makes the case for additional standards centered on meaningful human control. The article brings a distinctly human question into debates often dominated by technological capability: not simply what autonomous weapons can do, but what decisions societies are prepared to delegate to them.

The final contribution places the tension between sovereignty and international responsibility in historical perspective. In "Human Rights and the United Nations in the Geopolitics of the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970)," Oluchukwu Ignatus Onianwa examines why sustained humanitarian concern over the Nigeria–Biafra conflict failed to produce substantive UN political intervention. Drawing on archival material from The National Archives in London and the United Nations Headquarters in New York, the article reconstructs the interaction among human rights advocacy, great-power calculations, African diplomacy, and the UN Secretariat. British resistance to internationalization, more limited

initiatives by Canada and France, and the Organization of African Unity's insistence on sovereignty and territorial integrity narrowed the space available for UN action. U Thant's deference to the OAU framework ultimately kept the organization's role largely within the humanitarian sphere. The case demonstrates how the institutional treatment of human suffering can depend as much on prevailing conceptions of political authority and regional order as on the gravity of the humanitarian claims themselves.

These articles make clear why security remains such a difficult object of geopolitical analysis. It operates simultaneously at several levels. It concerns relations among major powers, but also regional actors seeking room for maneuver; institutions and legal rules, but also the political conditions under which those rules acquire force; military technologies, but also judgments about responsibility and legitimate violence. Historical experience further cautions against assuming that institutions will necessarily resolve these tensions simply because common rules formally exist.

For Global Geopolitics, this breadth is important. Geopolitics should remain attentive to territory, strategic rivalry, and distributions of power without treating them as self-contained explanations of international politics. The contributions to this issue show, in different ways, how questions of power are inseparable from the institutional and normative settings in which political actors operate. Security orders endure not simply because they reflect a particular balance of forces, but because states and societies find ways—sometimes successfully, sometimes not—to negotiate the limits of conflict, autonomy, responsibility, and coexistence.



Between Comity and Conflict

REVISITING EURASIAN SECURITY IN THE MULTIPOLAR ERA

Richard Sakwa

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Abstract

This article revisits Eurasian security by examining the unresolved tension between comity and conflict under conditions of contemporary multipolarity. How, and through what institutional–normative mechanisms, can Eurasian security be organized in a multipolar era without reverting either to hegemonic tutelage or to bloc-based confrontation? The analysis adopts genealogy as a historically grounded interpretive method that reconstructs the contingent processes through which security practices and political orders become possible, stabilized, and treated as self-evident. A limited set of historically significant episodes—ranging from the failed Volga Charter and the 1945 Yalta-Potsdam moment to the consolidation of the UN Charter International System and the rise and unmasking of the Political West—are examined through close reading of diplomatic exchanges, institutional documents, policy statements, and authoritative interpretations. The findings identify a durable “security gap” produced by the absence of a shared Eurasian normative framework in 1941–45, later compounded by contradictions between Charter-based sovereign internationalism and liberal-globalist ordering. The article concludes that heterar-

chical comity, anchored in Charter pluralism, provides the most plausible basis for a sustainable Eurasian security architecture under multipolarity.

Keywords

comity; Eurasian security; multipolarity; sovereign internationalism; world order

Introduction

During his visit to Moscow in December 1941, the British foreign minister, Anthony Eden, came prepared to discuss the contours of a postwar order. The focus of the talks was on strengthening the Anglo-Soviet wartime alliance, yet Eden had wider ambitions. Winston Churchill, the prime minister, was extremely reluctant to talk about postwar order, insisting that the priority was winning the war, and everything else was a distraction. However, to entice the United States into the war against Nazi Germany, Churchill agreed to the Atlantic Charter with the US president, Franklin D. Roosevelt. The Atlantic Charter, signed off the coast of Newfoundland in August 1941, outlined the fundamental principles of the war and the outlines of a postwar order. Since the US at the time was not a direct combatant, the document necessarily avoided specific operational matters and instead concentrated on abstract principles. Churchill was forced to make important concessions, including opening the British Empire to American commerce. In return, the UK received increasing quantities of war materiel delivered through the Lend-Lease programme. The Atlantic Charter would later become the foundation of the Washington Treaty of April 1949, establishing the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO).

In his visit to Moscow, Eden was thinking of an equivalent for Eurasia, which he dubbed the “Volga Charter” (Hall, 2014). This venture proved stillborn, with discussions in the Kremlin focusing on Joseph Stalin’s immediate demands, above all recognition of Soviet borders as they existed before the German invasion of 22 June that year, including the parts of Finland ceded after the Winter War (1939-40), the Baltic States, Eastern Poland and Northern

Romania. Neither the British nor American governments were prepared to recognize these territorial changes. Nevertheless, the visit prepared the way for the Anglo-Soviet Treaty of Mutual Assistance of May 1942, which in turn laid the foundation for the wartime Grand Alliance. As for the broader vision of a postwar order, no common framework was established. The alliance would not last much beyond the end of the war. The path was set, and the lack of a normative foundation, equivalent to the Atlantic Charter, meant that the anti-Axis alliance did not endure. The problem of North Eurasian security has still not been resolved.

This article takes Eden's stillborn "Volga Charter" as a point of departure to revisit the enduring tension between comity and conflict in Eurasian security. It is guided by a central question: how, and through what institutional–normative mechanisms, can Eurasian security be organized in a multipolar era without reverting either to hegemonic tutelage or to bloc-based confrontation? From a methodological perspective, this question is addressed through genealogy, understood here as a historically grounded interpretive research method that investigates how political orders and security practices become possible, stabilized, and taken for granted over time, rather than as an inquiry into origins or linear causation (Vucetic, 2011). Genealogy proceeds by problematizing what appears natural in the present and reconstructing the contingent historical processes through which it emerged. In practical terms, this involves identifying a limited number of historically significant episodes, assembling a focused archive for each episode (including diplomatic exchanges, institutional documents, policy statements, and authoritative interpretations), and subjecting these materials to close interpretive reading. The analysis traces how specific discourses and institutional arrangements structured what could be said, negotiated, and institutionalized at each juncture, while simultaneously marginalizing alternative possibilities. By moving iteratively across episodes and examples, genealogy shows how earlier settlements constrained later choices and how power operated productively through norms, institutions, and expectations rather than through direct coercion.

In this study, genealogy is applied by tracing how Eurasian security arrangements came to be constituted through a series of contingent historical settlements—from the failed Volga Charter and the 1945 Yalta–Potsdam moment to the Charter system and the rise of the Political West—rather than treating them as the product of fixed strategic logics. By reconstructing these episodes through close reading of diplomatic practices, institutional designs, and normative claims, the analysis shows how comity and conflict were historically produced, stabilized, and reconfigured under changing conditions of power and multipolarity. In this context, the argument is that the failure to articulate a shared Eurasian normative framework in 1941–45 produced an enduring “security gap” that later interacted with the post-1945 settlement’s own contradictions—above all the uneasy overlap between the Charter International System and competing models of world order, from Yalta–Potsdam sovereign internationalism to the liberal-globalist project of the Political West. The argument is constructed in four stages: it reconstructs the contradictions of the 1945 settlement; traces the rise, endurance and recent unmasking of the Political West; develops a four-dimensional framework for understanding multipolarity; and concludes by assessing whether heterarchical comity can provide a viable basis for Eurasian security in the present era.

1945: Year of Contradictions

The Yalta and Potsdam conferences in 1945 established the principle of the comity of the great powers, which was entrenched in the newly established United Nations in the form of the five permanent members of the Security Council. Russia repeatedly calls for the restoration of the ‘Yalta-Potsdam’ system, reflecting the high point of its power and international recognition. However, Yalta-Potsdam was not a system but a model of world order, something very different. The international system today is the one established in 1945: the Charter International System, based on the UN and the vast body of agencies, international law and norms established on its foundations. By contrast, Yalta-Potsdam is a model of world

order at the level of international politics. There is, nevertheless, congruity between the Charter system and the Yalta-Potsdam order: a common commitment to sovereign internationalism. Hence Russia's contemporary desire to return to that order, which also entails support for the UN system.

The leaders at the Yalta conference in February 1945 sought to establish a peacetime grand alliance to guarantee peace and security for all countries after the war. This was taken a step further at the Potsdam meeting in July 1945. A Council of Ministers was created to negotiate Europe's postwar territorial and political order. Super-power summits, which until 1955 included the UK, continued this tradition. Yalta is often misrepresented as carving up Europe into spheres of influence, and this myth has resonance to this day when the specter of a second Yalta great power deal over the head of Europe hung over the talks to end the Ukraine war. However, as Geoffrey Roberts stresses, there was no such discussion of spheres of influence at Yalta. Indeed, the conference was devoted not to dividing Europe but to unifying it under the combined tutelage of the three victorious great powers of the Second World War – Britain, the Soviet Union and the United States. The key political resolution agreed by the Big Three – the Declaration on Liberated Europe projected a politically united continent based on democracy and anti-fascism (Roberts, 2025b).

Nevertheless, the myth of Yalta as the “great betrayal” lives on, symbolizing the division of Europe into spheres of influence without regard for the interests of small and medium states. In fact, the leaders at Yalta envisaged a united Europe managed on comity principles. Dividing lines emerged because of ‘the complex dynamics between great powers and their leaders, solidified by the post-war realities on the ground’. The pro-Soviet regimes in eastern Europe “unfolded amid escalating confrontation with the West – and, crucially, was never predetermined at Yalta or Potsdam” (Bespalov, 2025).

At the level of international politics after 1945 two models of world order emerged, whose contestation between 1947 and 1989 took the form of a Cold War. The Political West, covering the

western part of the continent and North America, opposed the Soviet bloc, encompassing the rest of North Eurasia and Central Asia. The Soviet bloc, like the Soviet Union itself, proved a brittle formation. The combination of ideological rigidity and inflexible geopolitical imperatives inhibited a more stable transition towards the creation of an organically rooted hegemonic system, and instead stability remained mechanical, policed by a rampant state apparatus and the force of arms. The Soviet bloc, in these terms, was truly a creation of the Cold War and disintegrated with the end of the Cold War, followed in short order by the collapse of the Soviet Union itself in December 1991.

On the other side, the US-led transatlantic alliance system is usually described by Russian commentators as the “collective West”, although it is more accurately described as the “Political West”, to denote its contingent character. It was also created during the Cold War and remains stamped with the legacy of cold war institutional and ideological characteristics. However, unlike its Soviet counterpart, instead of dissolving at the end of the Cold War, as most wartime alliances do after achieving their goals, the Political West radicalized. It now claimed certain universal rights, thus usurping the prerogatives that properly belong to the Charter system. In stark contrast to the sovereign internationalism at the heart of the Charter system, and professed by the Yalta-Potsdam order, the world order represented by the Political West advances liberal globalism, the view that the only viable and universal model of modernity is the one represented by the Political West. Liberal globalism combines a political project based on reified notions of ‘freedom’; an economic agenda demanding free markets, open trade and minimum state management of the economy; and a geopolitical ambition to maintain the primacy of the US. These three elements were not always compatible but nevertheless created a powerful model of world order in the first eight postwar decades. Liberal globalism, variously described as the liberal international order, liberal hegemony or the rules-based international order, entailed an entitlement, if not obligation, to interfere in the internal affairs of states if they are believed to have

contravened elements of the normative order represented by the Political West.

The Political West endured, whereas the endless contingencies of the Soviet bloc proved less durable. This is paradoxical, since classical Marxist-Leninist theory would suggest that a community founded on socialist principles would have greater internal coherence than one established by competing capitalist democracies. In the event, it was the democratic capitalist model of world order that was fated to survive. It turned out that Karl Kautsky's model of 'ultra-imperialism', whereby the leading capitalist states created a de facto global cartel and learned to cooperate, was vindicated, whereas Lenin's theory about the inevitability of conflict between the imperialist powers was refuted – at least for a time. With the rise of Donald J. Trump's mercantile globalism and militarized forms of globalism more generally, Lenin may in the end be proved right. In the immediate term, the Atlantic Charter laid the foundations for an enduring transatlantic alliance, whereas the absence of an equivalent for Northern Eurasia set in motion the events that provoked the Russo-Ukrainian War from 2022. The Helsinki Final Act of August 1975 sought to fill the gap, with recognition of the Soviet Union's postwar borders (with the partial exception of the Baltic republics), but its focus on stabilizing Cold War relationships and normative issues failed to create firm foundations for great power comity after the end of the Cold War. The conceptual roots of contemporary debates over multipolarity lie in the liminal period of debates over the shape of postwar order.

The fundamental tension is between the contrasting dynamics of comity and conflict. After the First World War, two great German thinkers analyzed the conditions for enduring peace and stability in an anarchic international environment. The jurist Carl Schmitt (2006) opted for hierarchy and authoritarianism, whereas the historian Otto Hintze opted for confederalism and voluntary commitments. Both sought to avoid a repetition of the disastrous experience of war and the conditions that provoked the conflict in the first place. Schmitt favored empire in which a single authority would govern in discrete regional spaces, *Grossraum* in his terminol-

ogy. Schmitt identified the Holy Alliance, established after the Napoleonic wars, as a European civilizational ideal at odds with what he claimed to be the empty universalism of the League of Nations (Odysseos & Petito, 2007).^{*} By contrast, Hintze from the outset warned against underestimating the scope for cooperative and associative models of social order, the “horizontal and unforced solidarity among equals” (Streeck, 2024, p. 182). Hintze argued that free and equal individuals can associate in cooperative solidarity, thus rendering unnecessary subordination to hierarchical or authoritarian power systems. In his view, this federative approach applied as much to international affairs as to individuals in society. Peaceful cooperation can be achieved by voluntary coordination, without infringing on the freedom and sovereignty of the individual or the state. Rather than empire, Hintze favored *comity*, an association of nations for their mutual benefit, although he did not use the term. He called for a regional state system based on voluntary union, but deeply confederal in its composition rather than striving for the federal agenda of “ever closer union”.[†]

The character of spatiality was again taken up against the backdrop of the Second World War. Soon after the war and not long after the publication of his landmark book in 1944, *The Great Transformation: The Political and Economic Origins of Our Time*, Karl Polanyi (1945) published an article with the unassuming title *Universal Capitalism or Regional Planning?*. He explored the relationship between what he called ‘the organization of international life’ and the politics and institutions of the most important states of his time. Focusing on the three great powers of the era, the US, the Soviet Union and the UK, he argued that what was “at issue between the powers is not so much their place in a given pattern of power, as the pattern itself” (Polanyi, 1945, p. 86). This was a liminal moment, with liberal capitalism in crisis, world-revolutionary socialism on the

^{*} Carl Schmitt later summarised his thinking in *The Nomos of the Earth in the International Law of the Jus Publicum Europaeum*, Translated and annotated by G. L. Ulmen (New York, Telos Press Publishing, 2006). For analysis, see Odysseos & Petito, 2007.

[†] For details of his thinking, see da Cunha, 2020.

march, and anti-imperial decolonization on the agenda. This made possible “a new era in international politics”, described by Wolfgang Streeck as one based on the “peaceful coexistence of diverse regimes in the regions of the world, based on differing ways of settling class conflict” (Streeck, 2024, p. 2). However, he was concerned that the US aspired to become a global power and thus sought world domination, which would “thwart the prospect of establishing a pluralistic world order and, thus, of a non-aligned third way towards regional planning” (Streeck, 2024, p. 269).

This brings us back to 1945. The Yalta and Potsdam conferences that year established the principle of the comity of the great powers, which was entrenched in the newly established UN in the form of the five permanent members of the Security Council. Russia repeatedly calls for the restoration of the “Yalta-Potsdam” system, reflecting the high point of its power and international recognition. However, as noted, Yalta-Potsdam was not a system but a model of world order, something very different. The fundamental Russian goal, now joined by China and some other states, is to generate precisely the pluralism promised in 1945, before it was overtaken by the bloc politics and bipolarity of the Cold War era. The desired spatiality is sovereign internationalism, advancing pluralism of social orders and geopolitical multipolarity, against the homogenizing impulse at the heart of liberal globalism. Spatiality at this point intersects with temporality. The contemporary striving for multipolarity is set against the longer historical context, and above all the manifold possible representations of “the West” itself. These include the civilizational West, expanding across the globe since 1492; or as a cultural formation with its roots in Judeo-Christian and Greco-Romano traditions. As the Political West begins to fragment, deeper political patterns and representations emerge to shape debates over territoriality.

The unresolved contradictions of the 1945 peace settlement shape international affairs today, just as the legacy of Versailles in the end determined interwar international politics. The current manifestation of the Yalta-Potsdam order is the alignment of Russia, China and the other states in the BRICS Plus association,

which can be considered as a nascent Political East, although with a very different political valance and normative foundations. The Charter system has now matured, and the great majority of states in the Global South variously pursue balancing, hedging or non-alignment strategies. Barely a generation separated the two world wars, whereas three generations have now passed since 1945. That does not mean that the issues are any less urgent. We remain trapped in another interwar era, although a much longer one than the mere twenty years between the great wars of the twentieth century.

Comity and Heterarchy

The Charter system was established in the wake of the most devastating conflict in human history. The UN Charter aspires to abolish war as an instrument of policy, and various subsequent declarations and conventions, above all the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the Genocide Convention of 1948, established the principles for a more humane and cooperative world order. There was no Henry Carey-like vision of *The Harmony of Interests*, but an attempt to manage competing interests. The normative foundation of the new order is sovereign internationalism, enshrining respect for the sovereignty of member states (including limits on interference in their domestic affairs), accompanied by the robust multilateralism enshrined in the Security Council and its five permanent members. This sovereign internationalism stands in stark contrast to globalist projects, of which liberal globalism was the dominant form in the post-war era until superseded by Trump-style *Machtpolitik*. Even at its height, the commonwealth dimension of the delivery of global public goods was entwined with American-style imperial globalism, intent on establishing and maintaining US global primacy. Shorn off its commonwealth trimmings, from the mid-2020s imperial globalism represented an incoherent combination of mercantile competitiveness with “America First” ambition to “normalize” US foreign policy to foster domestic development and reindustrialization. The distinction between internationalism and varieties of globalism, however, remained.

Instead of a progressive spiral of history, in which the lessons of past failures bring about future achievements, the radicalization of the Political West in the post-communist era undermined even the achievements of the early postwar years. This is the tension between sovereign internationalism and liberal (and other types of) globalism. The academic Gerry Simpson (2001, pp. 539, 560) draws the same conclusion, describing the struggle between “charter liberalism” and “liberal anti-pluralism”. For him, the core of the post-1945 international system is the idea of “charter liberalism”, based on a pluralist representation of the international community. This is a “procedure for organizing relations among diverse communities”. This stands in contrast to “liberal anti-pluralism”, described by Simpson as “a liberalism that can be exclusive and illiberal in its effects”, above all in its ‘lack of tolerance for non-liberal regimes”. The latter is “an evangelical version that views liberalism as a comprehensive doctrine or a social good worth promoting and the other more secular tradition emphasizing proceduralism and diversity” (Simpson, 2001, pp. 539, 560). The evangelical version took the form of liberal globalism in the postwar years.

Instead of the comity and cooperation envisaged by the Charter, events developed in a very different direction. Conflict and hierarchy returned with a vengeance. Concurrent with the establishment of the Charter system, the major power of the day, the United States established its own model of world order, the Political West (the Atlantic power system, latterly dubbed, as we have seen, the rules-based international order, largely synonymous with the so-called liberal international order) based on liberal globalism. This precept is antithetical to multipolarity, since it believes in a single universal model of modernity. In pursuit of its goals, it sought to reshape the entire globe in its image. The return of Trump to the White House in January 2025 removed the veil masking the raw power that lay behind the hegemony of the Political West, and the real distribution of power within that order. Liberal globalism gave way to mercantile globalism, exposing the imperial aspirations underlying both. The curtain was drawn back, ending the era of double standards but revealing some rather harsh realities.

This was particularly uncomfortable for the European legacy powers. France, Germany and the other powers are faced with determinate choices. In the face of the potential defection of the US from the political order of its own creation, they can either try to maintain the Political West in its accustomed form, although with a lower US commitment, and thus perpetuate the organizational and ideological instruments of the Cold war, or to substantially revise the North Eurasian security order. That would mean reconciliation with Russia, and more broadly the renunciation of liberal globalism and the embrace of the realism at the heart of Yalta-Potsdam style sovereign internationalism. In this way, some of the contradictions of 1945 would be resolved. It is unlikely that this will be the choice. The Political West was largely the creation of the US, with Europe a willing accomplice but a largely subaltern actor.

This, at least, is the standard interpretation. But what if this model is not correct? What if the driving power behind the Political West is Europe, with the US taking advantage of Europe's willingness to subordinate itself to US strategic interests. US concerns were always larger and more global than those of Europe. If this is indeed the case, then the conclusion is clear: Europe will try to continue the Political West by other means. This is evident in the increased militarization of the EU. It is also manifest in the idea of creating a 'European NATO' or even a European Treaty Organization (ETO). The Starmer-Macron 'coalition of the willing', the term used to describe the alliance that launched the illegal and ultimately catastrophic invasion of Iraq, has been revived to continue support for Ukraine as the US began to pull away. The Political West is a constellation of power, but if its locus shifts from Washington to Brussels, then a very different ontology emerges. Washington is a global power, but the Political West is a regional endeavor. As the US goes elsewhere in the search for new monsters to destroy, Europe is left with its old nightmares. The tragedy is that it has reproduced monsters that had long been thought to have been put to rest.

During the Cold War, the Political West was constrained by the existence of another substantive model of world order, the Soviet bloc. With the collapse of the latter in 1989-91, the endemic

problem of substitution, whereby the Political West claims the universalism properly belonging to the Charter system, was exacerbated. Instead of being resolved, this contradiction has sharpened. The Charter system today is under unprecedented threat. The UN Security Council has become yet another platform for great power conflict rather than a forum for conflict resolution. Reform of the UN is very much on the agenda, but for this to be meaningful a reconfiguration within international politics is required. This is the aspiration of the nascent post-Western anti-hegemonic world order, the Political East. Its challenge is neo-revisionist: to counter the logic of Western hegemony at the level of international politics; but to support and reinforce Charter norms at the systemic level.

This forces us to examine the potential of comity itself. Can a community based on comity deliver the requisite public goods? Is some sort of hegemon required to police the normative order for the delivery of public goods – including free trade, open markets, safe navigation, maintenance of the human rights norms embedded in the Charter and much else. Are there non-hegemonic means of overcoming collective action problems? Comity means a plural international order, in which sovereignty is defended but states come together based on *sovereign internationalism* to coordinate outcomes through multilateralism. In Europe, this does not necessarily mean some sort of European Union but could equally well work as a continent comprised of nation states, as proposed by Charles de Gaulle in the early years of the Common Market. This would be a Europe based on David Mitrany's (1943) functionalism. Mitrany's model is remarkably similar to the model of spatiality proposed by Hintze. A Europe of fatherlands is now the desirable outcome for various sovereigntist movement, typically miscategorized as 'populist'. In other words, rather than the integration of Europe as a Schmittian *Grossraum*, there is scope for a more pluralistic Hintzean comity model. Rather than hierarchy, heterarchy is becoming the organizing principle in international affairs (Cerny, 2023).

If we apply the distinction between system and order, then we may find a conceptual framework to substantiate the comity model. The Charter International System is based on the comity of

nations. The Charter system is far from a world government, yet it establishes the norms and rules of how international politics should be conducted. On its basis there is now a ramified network of institutions, agencies, protocols and a substantive body of international law. The Charter system's combination of sovereignty and internationalism built on and learned from the successes and failures of earlier international systems (Westphalia 1648, Utrecht 1714, Vienna 1815 and Versailles 1919). It is on that basis that multipolarity can develop and thrive. In fact, the entire postwar system of international relations is based on this idea.

At the same time, there are different types of comity. On the one side, there is *federative comity*, of the sort that was tried in the League of Nations and then more successfully implemented through the UN. In a multilateral format, formally equal states come together to resolve global problems in a robust normative framework and assign designated tasks to specialized agencies. On the other side, there is *great power comity*, of the sort that was practiced by the Allied leaders in the Second World War. This is the type of comity that Soviet and Russian leaders favor, with the Yalta-Potsdam meetings in 1945 considered a model for how great powers should manage international politics. The Yalta conference agreed the basic principles of the UN, including the voting rights of the permanent members of the UN Security Council. They were granted a veto on important decisions, a device to ensure great power unity and commitment to the new multilateral format to manage international politics. The wisdom of the UN is that it combines both types of comity, with the five permanent members of the Security Council enjoying veto rights, and thus incorporating great power comity into the workings of an organization dedicated to federative cooperation. The veto system sought to generate great power consensus on global security issues. Great power comity is based on a profoundly pluralist approach to international politics, with a variety of types of economic organization and social systems. There is, nevertheless, a profound imbalance, with great power comity greatly overshadowing federative comity, as represented by the UN General Assembly. That is why discussion about UN reform focuses on ways to

enhance the status of the UNGA. The two types of comity are dedicated to a common goal – the avoidance of war – but a more influential UNGA would reflect the maturation of the system and the rising power of the Global South.

The tension between the two principles is an enduring feature of the Charter system. The fragile balance is always in danger of rupturing, usually to the detriment of the UN General Assembly and the federative principle. There is also the persistent threat that the great powers will establish comity relations entirely outside of the UN system. Thus, as Geoffrey Roberts (2025a) argues, Russo-US rapprochement offers a pathway to peace in Ukraine. But his argument goes further: “ending the war could catalyse a radical reconstruction of Russo-American relations – towards a global compact between Washington and Moscow that, together with China and other Great Power partners, would underpin a stable, multipolar system of sovereign states”. The character of this ‘global compact’ is unclear, although it is clearly based on a sovereign internationalism unmoored from the normative foundations of the Charter system.

By contrast, in his application of the New Political Thinking in the final years of the Soviet Union, the last Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev sought to meld the two forms of comity into a new and more integrated form, a higher-level comity that would preserve the pluralism of international politics but with a greater emphasis on international cooperation to establish a global federative peace order. This would not be world government, but comity taken to a higher level. The refusal of the Western powers to accord equal recognition and status to the Soviet Union/Russia and its legitimate security interests was one of the proximate causes of the first Cold War and which ultimately provoked the second. This generated a chronic problem of ontological insecurity in Russia, accompanied by a recessive obsession with Yalta-Potsdam. For a short period, Moscow had precisely been accorded its desired status.* Today it

* For analysis along similar lines, from which this account draws, see Pechatnov, 2025.

makes Russia a dedicated supporter of the Charter system, where it enjoys the status of a permanent member of the UNSC. At the level of international politics, however, Washington's struggle for primacy precludes such recognition, generating tensions that are now extended to US relations with China.

The Four Dimensions of Multipolarity

Multipolarity has long been on the agenda in international politics. In Russia, the foreign minister (1996-98) and then prime minister (1998-99), Evgeny Primakov, was an early exponent of the idea that no state could hope to maintain its dominance. His advocacy of multipolarity was immediately recognized for what it was – a challenge to US hegemony. Primakov was the architect of the RICs alignment of Russia, India and China, although the move was premature and the current of history only caught up a few years later. In 2009, Putin convened the first meeting of the BRIC (with Brazil added to the original RIC) leaders in Ekaterinburg, joined the following year by South Africa.

Any view of multipolarity that retains a US- or Atlantic-basin centered view is anachronistic, and even perverse. The US remains the world's dominant military and economic power, but Europe has become increasingly marginalized. Above all, multipolarity presumes the absence of a single hegemon, and thus entails bargaining between great powers. Implicitly, this means some sort of concert arrangement if not fully-fledged great power comity. It does not necessarily entail a fully-fledged universalistic counterweight to the Political West or the US, but it does suggest a more heavily entrenched character to international politics. When Soviet and now Russian scholars talk of the Yalta-Potsdam system, this is what they mean. These hopes were soon dashed, and within two years the first Cold War chilled relations between the victors of 1945. An era of bipolar bloc politics set in. When that thawed in 1989, it was replaced by the "unipolar moment", that in the end was assumed to last indefinitely (Krauthammer, 1990; 2002). The US-led bloc, and the US itself, claiming certain universal preroga-

tives that properly belong to the Charter system. From the beginning Russian commentators, notably Primakov, called for multipolarity, but at this stage this was more an aspiration than a reality. Multipolarity is now becoming a reality, but what does it mean? What is a “pole” in international politics? There are several definitions.

First, the normative. The Charter principle of sovereign internationalism balances between sovereignty and multilateral internationalism. This means that the 193 states represented in the UN formally enjoy equal sovereignty. The former colonial states have mostly consolidated their statehood, and none (except the Europeans) is ready to temper its sovereignty for a renewed subaltern status. The nation-state is the ready-made instrument of polarity – each represents a pole in and of itself. Of course, some are small and some are great, some have been able to mobilize their economic and political resources, others have slipped back into neo-colonial dependency, while others have pooled elements of their sovereignty into supranational bodies, as in the EU. The big story, however, is the maturity of the Charter International System and the consolidation of the statehood of the postcolonial and post-communist states, as well as those in thrall to the great powers during the Cold War, notably in Latin America. A plethora of middle powers temper the dominance of the great and legacy powers and endows international politics with unprecedented fluidity and dynamism. This represents an epochal change and provides the foundations for a more thoroughgoing federative comity of nations based on functionalist internationalism. The Global South now demands a greater say in international affairs, above all though activating the reserve powers of the UN General Assembly vested in the Charter.

The second definition of multipolarity focuses on structural factors, the material distribution of power and resources. The relative power and military resources of states, above all the relative rise of Asia (and potentially Africa), and the relative decline of the West, is at the center of analysis. In this context, the meta-event of the current period is the ineluctable shift in the global economic center of gravity from the Atlantic basin to the Asia-Pacific region, from

the Political West to the Global South, accompanied by a potent demographic surge in Africa. In purchasing parity terms (PPP), China caught up with the US in 2014, although in nominal and per capita income terms still falls far short (nominal GDP in 2025 was \$19.6 trillion, compared to the US at \$30.75 trillion). India is one of the most rapidly developing countries in the world, along with what had earlier been called the Asian ‘tigers’ – including Vietnam, Indonesia, Malaysia and Thailand. They became manufacturing and commercial hubs, while Singapore retains its pre-eminence in financial services. In 2000, the G7 countries controlled 65 per cent of global GDP, but by 2022 this had fallen to around 40 per cent. The BRICS+ countries represent a slightly larger share when measured in PPP terms. The G7 countries make up 30.3 per cent of global GDP in PPP terms, while the ten BRICS+ states represent 37 per cent, although the G7 remains ahead in nominal terms. In terms of population, the disparity is even more striking, with the BRICS nations home to over 46 per cent of the world’s population, while the G7 accounts for less than ten per cent.

The Ukraine war brought into sharper focus the emergence of competing alignments, which we earlier conceptualized as the US-led Political West against a nascent Political East. The Sino-Russian alignment is at the core of the latter, along with a host of non- and weakly-aligned powers in the Global South. A new era of multipolarity is evident, with a constellation of diverse actors in international politics. The Russian foreign minister, Sergei Lavrov, considered the Ukraine war a consequence of the West’s failure to adjust to the changed realities. He argues that “today the world is living through the ‘multipolar moment’. Shifting towards the multipolar world order is a natural part of power rebalancing, which reflects objective changes in the world economy, finance and geopolitics. The West waited longer than the others, yet it has also started to realize that this process is irreversible”. He noted the increasing role of regional associations, such as the Eurasian Economic Union, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, ASEAN, the African Union, CELAC (Community of Latin American and Caribbean states), and others. In his view, “BRICS has become a model of

diplomacy. The UN should remain a forum for aligning the interests of all the countries” (O’Connor, 2024).

Third, the realist approach is the classic one, seen through the prism of American-style realist International Relations, where the focus is on power, capacity and intent. The dominant paradigm here is Kenneth Waltz’s neo-realism. The focus is on great powers and their ability to forge constellations of states aligned with them. In the Cold War bipolar era the Soviet bloc was ranged against the US-led Political West. After the Cold War, the US emerged supreme, feeding illusions that the unipolar era would endure indefinitely. In the event, anti-hegemonic constellations emerged, above all the Political East alignment of Russia and China. In an anarchic international environment, this bloc-style multipolarity focuses on the balance of power, spheres of influence and demarcated regional alignments. In conditions where American dominance, in hard and soft power terms, remains overwhelming, this perspective tends to be critical of the notion of multipolarity, dismissing the concept as no more than a futile weapon of the weak (Brooks & Wohlforth, 2023). At most, American neo-realists concede that China is emerging as a peer competitor, and therefore elements of Cold-War style bipolarity are emerging. The rest are consigned to a residual category, where they play in the loser’s pool of balancing, hedging or some other subaltern strategy.

Fourth, the systemic model is one that underlies the idea of comity, and the pluralism outlined by Simpson and advanced by Gorbachev. In his vision of a common European home, Gorbachev envisaged that it would be a house with many rooms, hosting a variety of models of world order, ideologies and geopolitical centers. This is precisely the agenda facing the world today. Its most developed institutional representation is the BRICS+ as an international organization, designed not to balance US hegemony, but to challenge the very idea of hegemonism in international politics. In these terms, it is anti-hegemonic (challenging the principle of hegemonism) rather than counter-hegemonic, trying to beat the hegemon at its own game, thus assuming hegemonic characteristics itself. To the degree that it acts as a counterweight, it appeals to the

Charter system principle of sovereign internationalism as opposed to liberal and imperial globalism, but its challenge at the level of international politics is asymmetrical. It does not present itself as a universalistic model of world order, unlike the Political West. BRICS is anti-hegemonic rather than counter-hegemonic. If it was simply the latter, it would ultimately reproduce the pattern of behavior that it ostensibly challenges. Hence the group is neither an alliance nor a bloc. It is certainly not an alignment of autocracies, as suggested by some critics, but a genuinely global organization. Its original five members (Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) includes democracies, so-called autocracies and the world's largest communist power. In 2024 they were joined by Egypt, Ethiopia, UAE and Iran (Saudi Arabia demurred, for a time at least), and in 2025 Indonesia. To these ten there are another ten partner countries hailing from several regions with a diversity of social systems: Belarus, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Nigeria, Uganda, Cuba, Bolivia, Malaysia, Thailand and Vietnam, with the application of dozens more pending. The group lacks a common social or political ideology, but they share a commitment to the Charter norm of sovereign internationalism and anti-hegemonism (the latter couched in various ways, including continued anti-colonialism and anti-imperialism). Their common goal is the reform of global governance "by promoting a more just, equitable ... representative ... multilateral system", as the Rio de Janeiro Declaration puts it, adopted at the 17th annual summit in July 2025 (quoted in Snider, 2025).

Conclusion: Hegemony or Comity

Sovereign internationalism gives expression to the diversity of the human experience, while remaining committed to the multilateral resolution of common challenges. The shift to systemic multipolarity entails a transformation of international politics away from endemic conflict towards the comity and cooperation envisaged by and reflected in the Charter system. This is the genuine new world order anticipated in 1945. A new generation now faces the chal-

lenge of overcoming the contradictions of 1945. All of this has a profound bearing on Eurasian security. It means a return to the agenda outlined by Eden in 1941, and amid attempts to devise a Eurasian Charter for our times.

In 1945 the US agreed to compromise its unfettered freedom of action in international affairs in the belief that engagement with allies and adversaries through multilateral agencies would avoid the pitfalls of the interwar period while rendering US power more legitimate, and thereby more effective (Wertheim, 2020). This bargain between power and legitimacy proved remarkably effective and allowed the Political West to survive and triumph in the Cold War. However, the tension between the autonomy of the Charter International System and the institutions of liberal globalism were evident, although disguised during the Cold War. As Soviet power waned, from the 1970s a more assertive liberal hegemony emerged, initially eroding the Keynesian domestic bargain and then from the late 1970s challenging the legitimacy of the Soviet Union itself, a process aided by catastrophic Soviet mistakes, notably the invasion of Czechoslovakia in 1968 and Afghanistan in December 1979. The demise of the Soviet Union removed checks on liberal globalism and allowed its radicalization in the form of the expansive ambitions of a now unconstrained Political West (see Mearsheimer 2018; 2019). This in turn provoked not balancing as the main form of anti-hegemonic resistance but various anti-hegemonic alignments. The normative foundation of this is sovereign internationalism, the foundational principle of normative and systemic multipolarity, powered by structural changes in the global economy.

The retreat of liberal hegemony is a necessary condition for the international system to work as was implicitly part of the 1945 consensus, but it is not sufficient. The end of US tutelary politics may take forms that not only erodes the model of world order represented by the Political West but also the international system in which it is embedded. An American retreat opens space for China, Russia and other rising powers, and it is precisely this that Trumpian mercantile globalism seeks to counter. The contradictions of 1945 remain, but with the development of multi-faceted multipolarity the

conditions are potentially created for the fulfilment of the comity embedded in the Charter system.

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Corresponding Author Biography

Richard Sakwa (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6678-8820>) is Emeritus Professor of Russian and European Politics at the University of Kent, Canterbury, and Honorary Professor in the Faculty of Political Science at Moscow State University. He studied History at the London School of Economics and completed his doctorate at the Centre for Russian and East European Studies at the University of Birmingham. Before joining Kent in 1987, he taught at the Universities of Essex and California, Santa Cruz. Over the course of his career, he has also been affiliated with a

number of leading research institutions, including as Associate Fellow of the Russia and Eurasia Programme at Chatham House from 2002 to 2020, Senior Research Fellow at the National Research University–Higher School of Economics in Moscow from 2014 to 2024, and member of the Academy of Social Sciences from 2002 to 2022. He is widely known for his extensive scholarship on Soviet, Russian, and post-communist politics.

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Multipolarity and the Geopolitical Reorganization of the Eurasian Security Order

Li Zhengdong

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Abstract

How is accelerating multipolarity transforming the structure and stability of Eurasia's security order? Using Brzezinski's realist framework as an analytical methodology, the study reveals that multipolarity is not producing a stable balance in Eurasia but rather a fragmented and corridor-based security structure. The interaction between Western alliance fragmentation, the EU's limited strategic autonomy, and Russia's structural decline has generated overlapping zones of competition, power vacuums, and asymmetric deterrence. As a result, Eurasia is evolving into a "strategic collision belt" characterized by nested power configurations and heightened regional insecurity. The transatlantic alliance is confronting growing trends of internal power imbalance and strategic divergence. The United States is attempting to reassert its primacy through strategic disengagement and trade agreements, while the European Union is mired in institutional lag and fractured leadership on the question of strategic autonomy. The strategic misalignment between Germany and France, together with Central and Eastern European states'

“front-loaded” perception of the Russian threat, has further undermined the formation of a unified European security strategy. Meanwhile, Russia is experiencing a decline in influence within its traditional sphere, creating geopolitical power vacuums in regions such as the Caucasus and Central Asia and thereby intensifying uncertainty surrounding collective security across the Eurasian continent. In this process, Eurasian geopolitical power is undergoing its largest post-Cold War reorganization to date, while regional conflict risks are rising and uncertainty is steadily increasing.

Keywords

Eurasian multipolarity; geopolitics; Russian decline; security transformation; threat perceptions

Introduction

Since the end of the Cold War, the geopolitical landscape of the Eurasian continent has undergone a profound and complex reconfiguration, amounting to the largest reshuffling of power across Eurasia since the Second World War. Zbigniew Brzezinski offered a penetrating analysis of the broader trajectory of Eurasian geopolitics in *The Grand Chessboard*, arguing—drawing on Mackinder’s theory—that whoever controls Eurasia controls the “World Island” and can thereby shape the evolution of the global balance of power. Against this backdrop, Eurasia has increasingly become the central arena of global geopolitical rivalry, as major powers intensify competition over institutional discursive authority, strategic corridors, and regional primacy (Brzezinski, 2016). Yet with Donald Trump’s rise to power, cracks gradually emerged in transatlantic relations, exposing deep divergences between the United States and its European allies regarding security burdens, economic interests, and strategic priorities. This has not only weakened NATO’s traditional deterrent capacity, but has also posed major challenges to Europe’s pursuit of autonomous security-building. In particular, the misalignment between Germany and France—widely viewed as the EU’s core—over strategic vision and leadership, together with the

split between Central and Eastern European states and the Western European core over perceptions of the Russian threat, has further deepened Europe's strategic security dilemma.

At the same time, Russia's structural decline triggered by the Russia–Ukraine war is driving a redistribution of Eurasia's power center of gravity. Its geopolitical influence in Central Asia and the Caucasus is visibly weakening, while China, Türkiye, and Western countries are gradually expanding their penetration into Russia's traditional sphere of influence. Leveraging the Belt and Road Initiative and regional cooperation mechanisms, China is seeking to fill the post-Russian vacuum through economic and institutional advantages, attempting to build a more flexible and enduring pattern of regional influence. Yet this strategic substitution faces severe tests stemming from sovereignty sensitivities, multilateral competition, and geopolitical complexity. NATO's continued eastward expansion and its efforts to shape Eurasian security corridors also indicate that the region's future security landscape will become more plural and more complex (Arynov & Sharipova, 2024).

Building on Brzezinski's realist analytical framework for Eurasian geopolitics, this study aims to think through, in depth, the reconstruction of Eurasia's geopolitical order in an era of multipolarity. Operationally, Brzezinski's realist analytical methodology can be applied through three steps. First, the analysis identifies the principal power centers and their relative capabilities. In this study, this step is operationalized by examining the United States/NATO, the European Union, Russia, and China as the primary strategic poles, assessing their alliance cohesion, military capacity, and influence projection across Eurasia. Second, it maps strategic corridors and geopolitical pivots that link regions (e.g., Baltic–Black Sea, Black Sea–Caspian, Central Asia connectivity routes). Here, the article applies this step by tracing how the Baltic–Black Sea axis, the Black Sea–Caspian corridor, and Central Asian connectivity routes function as contested geostrategic linkages where major powers compete for access, depth, and alignment. Third, it assesses how shifts in alliance cohesion, influence projection, and regional penetration alter the broader continental equilibrium. Accordingly, the study

analyzes how Western fragmentation, the EU's autonomy-capability gap, Russia's post-war contraction, and China's expanding regional engagement collectively reconfigure Eurasia's balance and generate layered insecurity. Therefore, today's Eurasia is no longer a stable buffer zone under a single hegemon; rather, it has become a "collision belt" of nested power and strategic contestation. Interlocking interests generate frequent institutional overlap and normative conflict, while regional security frictions and disputes may become the new normal. Eurasia's future geopolitical reorganization will thereby not only imply a more dispersed distribution of power centers, but also higher uncertainty and strategic risk. By analyzing the geopolitical demands of different major power actors, we can better anticipate the possible direction of the evolving geopolitical order and prepare for future risks and contingencies under conditions of uncertainty.

International Power Imbalance and Strategic Divergence Within the Western Alliance

U.S. "Strategic Retrenchment" and the Restructuring of Alliance Power

As the Eurasian geopolitical configuration accelerates toward multipolarity, the Western alliance—represented above all by NATO—is undergoing a deep transformation in its internal power structure. The most salient manifestation of this shift is that, under "America First," Trump has progressively withdrawn substantive U.S. investment in European security and has sought to "outsource" strategic responsibilities systematically to Europe's allies. The Trump administration repeatedly stated publicly that it wanted NATO members to raise defense spending to 5% of GDP. This not only signals a strategic retrenchment of U.S. military resource commitments within NATO, but also reflects a pragmatic calculation that treats NATO as a "cost-controlled security instrument," rather than an irreplaceable strategic pillar (Hilse, 2020). Although such measures preserve organizational stability in form, they create an institutional

rupture in function and in the distribution of rights and responsibilities. This strategic move by the Trump administration would fundamentally alter the geopolitical balance of power across Eurasia.

First, this is evident in Trump's weakening of NATO's commitments to support Ukraine. In early July 2025, the White House announced a suspension of certain categories of military aid to Ukraine, drawing widespread attention among European allies. The internal logic was not merely a reassessment of the global allocation of military assistance, but also an indirect demand that Europe "assume security responsibilities autonomously." Although the 2025 Hague Summit pushed member states to raise defense spending and strengthen collective defense mechanisms, the summit's outcomes treated the Ukraine issue only lightly, and its rhetoric toward Russia was noticeably toned down. This strategy—"expressing support politically while preserving institutional flexibility"—has made NATO's response to security challenges increasingly characterized by strategic ambiguity and fragmented resolve (Cancian & Park, 2025; Fenbert, 2025).

This U.S. "strategic disengagement" has produced a pronounced sense of security anxiety within Europe. While the Franco-German axis still seeks to lead Europe's strategic autonomy agenda, it lacks substantive consensus on key issues such as assistance to Ukraine, burden sharing in defense spending, and the construction of a future security framework. Some Central and Eastern European states, by contrast, are more inclined to rely on continued U.S. military commitments, viewing them as essential guarantees against the Russian threat—especially those located on NATO's eastern flank. This mismatch between security dependence and political trust has created serious rifts within NATO over threat perception, strategic priorities, and resource allocation, making it difficult to consolidate a unified collective strategic will. More fundamentally, Ukraine's status as a potential NATO member has long remained suspended between "political dependence" and "institutional marginality," reflecting NATO's reluctance to assume the collective security and war responsibilities that formal membership could entail (Sirbiladze, 2022).

Meanwhile, although most NATO members declared during the 2025 Hague Summit that they would increase defense spending, implementation faces severe constraints. Germany, for example, suffers from aging equipment and generally low readiness rates, and it lacks the capacity to complete military modernization in the short term. In 2024, Germany's defense spending was only 1.9% of GDP—far below the newly proposed 5% threshold. Southern European states, facing fiscal stress and domestic opposition, are even more cautious about sustaining high-intensity long-term defense spending. Spain's prime minister explicitly noted that meeting NATO's new spending standard would require Spain to invest up to an additional €300 billion in defense over the next decade—an increase that would produce structural austerity in public services such as health-care and education. Clearly, NATO's defense-spending surge plan not only intensifies divisions among allies, but also triggers fierce domestic disputes across Europe over policy priorities (Stengel, 2025; Blackburn, 2025).

This U.S. strategic pullback will also reshape NATO's role boundaries in global security governance. The United States would gradually lose its role as the strategic “balancer” across Eurasia. As Eurasia's Western flank has long functioned as a key pivot for the United States to manage Eurasian equilibrium, losing control over that pivot would inevitably weaken America's ability to shape the broader continental balance. In the short term, Trump's push for allies to increase defense spending and prioritize purchases of U.S.-made equipment not only expands the market share of the American defense industry in Europe, but also signals his attempt to construct a new model of rights and responsibilities in a period of strategic retrenchment: “others bear the burdens, while the United States coordinates.” This decision would not only erode the traditional foundations of transatlantic security trust, but could also cause NATO to gradually lose, at the level of institutional logic, its functional character as a unified strategic community. The arms-race dynamics, regional strategic instability, and imbalanced flows of global governance resources induced by surging defense budgets will become key variables shaping the stability of Eurasia's next-

stage geopolitical order. What is more, NATO's intense focus on the Russia–Ukraine battlefield has already compressed its strategic attention and policy investment in other regional conflicts. Even more importantly, massive defense expenditures will continue to crowd out the fiscal space available to multilateral mechanisms such as the EU and the UN for key agendas including sustainable development, climate governance, and humanitarian assistance—thereby affecting the resilience of Global South countries under today's complex international conditions. In short, under deepening multipolarity, the Western alliance is confronting not merely a strategic reorganization, but a multi-level reconstruction of power logic, institutional legitimacy, and regional responsibility. NATO is situated on a fault line between traditional security mechanisms and new multilateral pressures; whether it can adapt to this changing strategic environment and preserve the institutional stability of a transatlantic security community will profoundly shape the future trajectory of the Eurasian order.

The Intensification of Transatlantic Trade and Economic Frictions

In an era in which geopolitics and geo-economics are deeply intertwined, the institutional transfer of NATO burdens is only one dimension of the United States' shift in strategic focus. A deeper change lies in Washington's use of economic instruments to pursue institutional integration and reshaping of its allies. On July 28, 2025, the United States and the EU formally signed a wide-ranging new trade agreement, marking not only continued U.S. burden reduction in security and stronger demands for allied self-reliance, but also an active attempt to reconstruct American leadership within the trade and economic system. The agreement establishes a uniform 15% baseline tariff covering key sectors such as semiconductors, automobiles, and pharmaceuticals; it also embeds the EU more deeply into U.S.-led global industrial and energy networks through large-scale energy purchase commitments and major investment pledges (Gray & Shalal, 2025). In this process, the United States is not simply pursuing traditional protectionism in isolation;

rather, by combining security retrenchment with economic embedding, it effectively converts geopolitical retreat into geo-economic dominance. This new pathway not only reshapes the basic structure of transatlantic relations: NATO's strategic "disengagement" and the reorganization of trade relations are not merely processes of military and industrial decoupling, but also a deep reallocation of political influence. Trump's policy not only shakes the long-established institutional trust between the United States and Europe, but also directly impacts the EU's structures of institutional dependence across economic, technological, and security domains.

Although the EU agreed to sign the new trade agreement, it appears that many details have not been concretely finalized—especially regarding emerging fields such as digital manufacturing, biotechnology, and high-end equipment manufacturing. At present, the agreement remains highly uncertain, and the Trump administration may continue to apply pressure on allies through additional economic measures. Trump's fundamental motivation is not trade *per se*; rather, it is to compress allies' policy space through tariffs and subsidies in order to protect U.S. dominance within global high-technology industrial chains.

This logic of "economy first" and "strategic instrumentalization" stands in fundamental contradiction to the EU's rules-based governance. The EU has long emphasized multilateralism and institutional balance, seeking to resolve trade disputes through the WTO system and regional agreements, whereas the Trump administration has increasingly favored a U.S. national-interest-centered approach that bypasses multilateral mechanisms and relies on unilateral pressure and bilateral bargaining to achieve geo-economic objectives. This misalignment in institutional orientation has, in effect, gradually migrated from the economic realm into the structure of strategic trust, pushing the alliance logic from "institutional isomorphism" toward "institutional attrition," and delivering a major shock to Europe's strategic positioning and global identity.

More complex still, the deepening of trade and economic frictions not only weakens U.S.–EU industrial coordination, but also materially constrains the EU's capacity to enhance defense auton-

omy. As NATO's defense-spending threshold rises sharply, European allies are forced to dramatically increase fiscal inputs to complete military modernization and rebuild strategic reserves. Yet against the backdrop of sluggish growth and a worsening trade environment, EU states face escalating pressure on public finances. High inflation, an energy crisis, and growing reliance on exports to the U.S. market make it difficult for the EU to balance defense spending with social expenditures, thereby objectively weakening its ability to respond to NATO's spending targets. This further intensifies structural frictions between the United States and Europe over security responsibilities and strategic rights and obligations. In sum, Trump's tariff policy functions as a tool in what is effectively a "resource-grab war" over the future structure of global power, while the EU is repeatedly constrained in practice by insufficient economic capacity and high dependence on the U.S. market. This not only deepens systemic fractures in transatlantic relations, but also places the EU in a dual dilemma between institutional rationality and material constraint in global geopolitical competition. Seen in this light, U.S.–EU relations are shifting from a traditional security-and-values alliance toward a partnership increasingly defined by differentiated interest structures—an evolution that could profoundly shape the trajectory and stability of the broader Eurasian geopolitical order.

The Practical Predicament of European Security

The Systemic Lag in the EU's Autonomous Security Capacity

The problems and contradictions Europe faces today do not stem solely from U.S. strategic adjustment and tariff pressures; internal EU issues also place it in an increasingly awkward strategic position. On the one hand, the EU views itself as a major actor in global governance, bearing a dual identity as both a norm-setter and a security provider. On the other hand, structural deficiencies in security capabilities and strategic coherence increasingly reduce it to a passive actor within the competitive landscape among great powers. This paradox is not only reflected in the deep continuation of

dependence on the United States, but is also rooted in the strategic rupture between Germany/France and Central and Eastern European states, as well as the imbalance between institutional design and geopolitical realities.

Europe's security predicament is, to a large extent, driven by deep structural dependence on the NATO system. In the post-Cold War period and even during security reassessments before the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine war, the EU did not establish genuine strategic autonomy; instead, it continued to outsource core security functions to U.S.-led NATO. From joint command structures and operational intelligence systems to procurement standards and officer training mechanisms, the military systems of major EU states have long been embedded within NATO's institutional architecture. This external dependence not only slows Europe's ability to act in crises, but also deprives it of autonomy and rapid response capacity in key strategic decision-making (Howorth, 2020).

Although defense spending has increased in recent years in some European countries—especially Germany and France—and France has even proposed building a “European army,” the practical challenges are far more urgent than headline figures suggest. First, the EU's overall military foundation is extremely weak. In particular, after decades of reliance on U.S. security provision, Europe's defense-industrial chain is seriously deficient in both equipment and human capital. For example, heavy weapons and air-defense systems pledged repeatedly to Ukraine have encountered production delays, logistical bottlenecks, and technical adaptation problems in actual delivery—revealing systemic shortcomings in European defense industry capacity (Alipour, 2025). Second, the theoretical blueprint of “strategic autonomy,” given both the lack of a viable substitute for U.S. military power and the absence of unified political lines within the EU, has largely remained at the level of political rhetoric. The EU has attempted repeatedly to reduce dependence on NATO through mechanisms such as the “European Defense Fund” and “rapid deployment forces,” yet in terms of scale, coordination, and operational capability, these arrangements cannot constitute a substantive replacement for a U.S.-led security system. More

crucially, a long-standing pacifist tradition in post-Cold War Western European political culture, combined with domestic fiscal constraints, has meant that political will to invest resources in rebuilding security systems has remained insufficient. Defense autonomy thus often devolves into technical details and bureaucratic coordination rather than a comprehensive redesign of national security strategy.

In addition, the EU's increasingly pronounced internal strategic heterogeneity further weakens the basis for integrating collective security capabilities. While Germany and France advocate, at the level of ideas, strengthening European sovereignty and enhancing strategic autonomy, their initiatives often face indifference—or outright resistance—among Central and Eastern European states. Grounded in historical memory and geopolitical realities, these states consistently view the United States as the ultimate guarantor of their security and harbor deep doubts about the Franco-German “de-Americanization” security path. After the Ukraine crisis, this strategic split became even more pronounced: Eastern European countries tend to “NATO-ize” and “Americanize” security issues, whereas Germany and France are more inclined to respond through diplomatic negotiations and European defense mechanisms—most clearly among states on the eastern border with Russia, particularly Poland. Such divergence undermines the EU's capacity to function as a unified security actor, making it more vulnerable to paralysis or purely symbolic gestures under external pressure (Velchev, 2024).

Structurally, Europe's current security dilemma reflects a deeper crisis of geopolitical identity. Traditionally, the EU sought to position itself as a “global exporter of norms,” shaping regional and even global order through economic integration and institutional construction. Yet in an era in which geopolitical logic has reasserted dominance, this kind of “institutional power and discursive authority” looks increasingly weak without corresponding hard-power support. As U.S.–China competition shapes the global structure and the Russia–Ukraine war shatters strategic buffers, the EU has been pushed back into a logic of great-power confrontation—without commensurate security capabilities or strategic cohesion. As a result,

the EU's role within a multipolar order has become increasingly ambiguous: it is neither able to function as a genuine "regional pole," nor able to serve steadily as a "balancing pivot" within major-power rivalry. This is particularly evident in the new tariff agreement signed by von der Leyen and the Trump administration, which underscores that the EU did not play a role as a geopolitical balancing pivot between China and the United States. Consequently, the EU will continue to confront an internal predicament: a weak military-security protection system coupled with a continuing decline in democratic, institutional discursive authority. This predicament will not only affect the EU's strategic confidence and political cohesion for decades to come, but will also weaken its capacity to participate in the reconstruction of global governance and to project democratic institutional influence.

Franco-German Misalignment: Internal Divisions in EU Security Leadership

As the EU's strategic autonomy agenda continues, Germany and France—Europe's most powerful and influential dual core—constitute the basic internal architecture of European security. Especially after the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine war, the structural contradictions exposed in efforts to build a unified security strategy have further highlighted leadership divergences the EU faces amid the reconstruction of the geopolitical security order. France has consistently treated European strategic autonomy as a core objective of national security policy, emphasizing that the EU should reduce dependence on the United States across key areas such as defense, diplomacy, and technology. This strategic thinking is rooted in France's deep "sovereigntist" tradition; in the continuation of the Gaullist political legacy, France views the construction of an independent European security architecture as a necessary path toward reshaping European power and enhancing its international standing. Since 2017, the Macron government has continuously promoted institutional arrangements such as the "European Intervention Initiative," the "European Defense Fund," and the

“Strategic Compass,” seeking to build, with France as the axis, an internal European mechanism for security and defense coordination. This posture reflects strong vigilance and distrust toward a transatlantic security dependence path. However, while France has strategic ambition, it lacks the comprehensive capacity required to underpin EU strategic autonomy: whether in defense spending, force deployment, or global military presence, it cannot independently shoulder systemic security responsibilities. Its global influence remains more symbolic than material, lacking sufficient resources and alliance-mobilization capacity to lead a truly autonomous and unified European security architecture (Schmitt, 2017).

By contrast, Germany’s security policy posture appears more cautious and conflicted. On the one hand, Germany rhetorically supports strengthening EU strategic autonomy—especially after the Russia–Ukraine war, when Berlin advanced the “*Zeitenwende*” agenda and pledged to raise defense budgets and rebuild military capabilities, signaling a potential shift in strategic culture. For example, in July 2025, Germany stationed troops in Lithuania for the first time, indicating an attempt to demonstrate defense influence on Europe’s eastern flank. On the other hand, Germany’s concrete actions exhibit a strong tendency toward risk aversion: growth in defense spending has been slow, and the activation of the defense-industrial sector has been sluggish. The fundamental source of this contradiction lies in Germany’s historical constraints. Memories of Nazism and the Second World War remain politically sensitive domestically, meaning that any discussion of military expansion or rearmament easily triggers broad public caution and moral restraint among political elites. At the EU level, some member states also view a resurgent German military with suspicion, fearing that German strategic primacy could disrupt Europe’s internal balance of power (Swaney, 2025). In addition, Germany faces severe domestic fiscal pressures—particularly regarding refugee reception, the maintenance of welfare systems, and green transition costs—further limiting the strategic fiscal space available for defense and defense-industrial investment. These structural and institutional constraints collectively weaken both Germany’s capacity and will-

ingness to act as a “security pillar” within the EU’s strategic autonomy agenda.

More importantly, although France and Germany have shown some willingness to coordinate in responding to the Ukraine crisis, differences in strategic culture, deterrence concepts, and preferred diplomatic instruments make it difficult for the two to form a genuinely unified and stable dual core for the EU. The heterogeneity of their strategic paths prevents consistent consensus on key issues, undermining the coherence and execution capacity of EU external security policy. Achieving EU strategic autonomy is not merely a policy vision; it is a stringent test of institutional integration capacity and major-power coordination mechanisms. Under existing security structures and capability constraints, neither France nor Germany has unlimited ability to drive the security agenda unilaterally. France has political will and strategic ambition, but its limited economic scale and overseas mobilization capacity weaken the resource base for leading European defense transformation; Germany has economic strength and institutional influence, but remains insufficient in strategic culture, military experience, and political will (Meijer & Brooks, 2021). Therefore, the EU’s strategic autonomy path must rest on Franco–German strategic alignment as a precondition; coordination between the two in security concepts, division of labor in armaments, and institutional construction will constitute a key variable driving Europe’s security transformation. More broadly, France and Germany must not only reach agreement at the policy level, but also assume their respective strategic responsibilities in practice. France should integrate its geopolitical objectives more reasonably with collective European interests, while Germany should genuinely move beyond historical burdens and accelerate military modernization. Only under these conditions can the EU, as an independent geopolitical actor, establish security agency and strategic coordinates amid U.S.–Russia competition and the reconstruction of a multipolar order.

A Split in Strategic Cognition: Central and Eastern Europe's Front-Loaded Perception of the Perceived Russian Threat

In the process of reshaping the EU's strategic security architecture, strategic cognitive differences among Central and Eastern European states constitute a variable that cannot be ignored—beyond the structural Franco–German divergence over defense paths and security burdens. In particular, as the Russia–Ukraine war continues to evolve, Central and Eastern European states' perception of the Russian threat has taken on a strongly front-loaded and operationalized character. Fundamental differences between these states and traditional core powers such as France and Germany—regarding threat perception, response pathways, and security prioritization—have become a key constraint preventing Europe from forming a unified geopolitical strategic stance. This split reflects not only the decisive role of geographic proximity and historical experience in shaping national security strategies, but also exposes deeper centrifugal political trends produced by multipolarized threat perceptions within Europe.

Central and Eastern European countries—especially Poland and the three Baltic states—experience intense security anxiety about Russia's strategic intentions and military threat due to direct border proximity and enduring memories of the Soviet period. After the Ukraine crisis erupted, these states rapidly shifted their security strategies comprehensively toward a “deterrence–defense” model. Their core idea is to strengthen national military capacity and consolidate bilateral security ties with the United States in order to build forward strategic depth along the regional front line (Zinoviev, 2025). Even Finland, long neutral during the Cold War, chose to join NATO. This strategic path manifests in three dimensions: first, the active deployment of U.S. and NATO forces to establish a normalized forward presence; second, a massive increase in defense spending—for example, Poland has planned to raise defense spending above 4% of GDP, making it one of Europe's highest; third, the promotion of regional multilateral security cooperation

mechanisms, such as the “Three Seas Initiative” and the “Bucharest Nine.”

In sum, severe strategic-cognition fragmentation has emerged between Central and Eastern European states on the front line of Russian security threats and other EU members. First, security priorities diverge: Central and Eastern Europe treats containing Russia as the most urgent task, whereas France and Germany lean toward strategic balance and crisis resilience management. Second, orientations toward Russia differ: Central and Eastern Europe advocates strengthened military deployments and deeper NATO involvement, while France and Germany prefer maintaining diplomatic maneuvering space and restoring a limited form of security dialogue. Third, the pace of rearmament and resource inputs is uneven: the former rapidly advances procurement and modernization, while the latter is constrained by fiscal limits and delayed political consensus—leading to frequent inconsistencies in assistance to Ukraine and undermining the coherence of NATO and EU policy overall. Accordingly, this structural divergence not only intensifies fragmentation in Europe’s security strategy, but also weakens, at the institutional level, the EU’s effectiveness as a collective security actor. Central and Eastern Europe is thus compelled to embed its security within the U.S.-led NATO framework rather than within EU internal defense structures, further eroding the EU’s voice and integrative capacity on security issues. At the same time, Germany and France—attempting to shape European security leadership—have failed to provide an effective collective-security guarantee mechanism, and thus cannot ease regional strategic anxieties. The result is an overall institutional failure and strategic imbalance in EU internal security.

Russia's Structural Decline: The "Influence Vacuum" in Its Traditional Sphere

The Postwar "Victory-Defeat Paradox" After the Russia-Ukraine War

The Russia-Ukraine war will not only reshape Eurasia's geopolitical order; it will also accelerate Russia's structural decline and gradually generate power vacuums in surrounding regions. Although Russia still maintains military control over parts of eastern Ukraine and has demonstrated tactical resilience on certain fronts, this cannot conceal the deeper trend of decline in comprehensive national power and strategic influence. In fact, what the war has triggered is not simply a military contest over Russian victory or defeat, but a structural trajectory in which—regardless of the outcome—Russia will be unable to reverse its longer-term decline.

The war has dealt a severe blow to Russia's national standing and strategic credibility. It has been widely seen as a source of regional instability, and it has significantly damaged Russia's great-power image as a UN Security Council permanent member purportedly serving as a "security provider." Eurasian states' acceptance of Russia as a regional great power has fallen rapidly, and the influence base Russia constructed across the post-Soviet space has visibly eroded. For example, countries in the Caucasus are seeking broader diplomatic options to reduce dependence on Russia. Azerbaijan, in particular, has long sought to escape Russia's geopolitical control over Baku (Brusylovska & Maistrenko, 2024). Meanwhile, Central Asian states are accelerating multilateral strategic coordination with external powers such as China and Türkiye. This decline in post-Soviet influence not only weakens Russia's control over its traditional sphere but also indicates that its role as a Eurasian "pivot" is being transformed into a strategic vacuum zone of multipolar contestation.

Long-term Western economic sanctions on Russia have slowed industrial transformation and severely constrained development in high-technology sectors. Large-scale financial and technological

sanctions have not only limited Russia's access to advanced technology and capital, but have also disrupted the international financial settlement networks on which its energy exports depend. Although Russia has maintained short-term macroeconomic stability through fiscal tightening, a ruble-centered domestic cycle, and redirection of energy exports to the Asia-Pacific, medium- and long-term structural problems are becoming increasingly pronounced. In particular, Russia faces a technology "lockout" in high-tech industries, manufacturing upgrading, and research capacity-building—constraints that make it difficult to support great-power military and diplomatic needs. As fiscal surpluses continue to shrink, Russia faces extreme strain in sustaining both wartime expenditures and domestic stability (Park, 2025). In addition, irreversible attrition of military capacity is a key sign of the contraction of great-power status. The war has pushed Russia's defense-industrial system into a high-consumption, low-replenishment dilemma; much conventional equipment derives from Soviet-era stockpiles, and once depleted, rapid replacement will be exceedingly difficult.

At an even deeper level, Russia's declining position in Eurasia is a historical exposure of post-imperial structural contradictions. After the Cold War, Russia sought to maintain an ambiguous balance between "sovereign revival" and "geopolitical integration," but it lacked sufficient economic foundations and institutional attractiveness to stabilize a sphere of influence over the long term. The Russia–Ukraine war shattered this balance and fully revealed the imperial nature of its external policy, leaving Russia unable to reconstitute leadership through non-alignment, regional cooperation, or multilateral institutions. This has triggered strategic escape by neighboring states while pulling Russia itself into a classic imperial dilemma of "having to expand while being unable to sustain expansion." The core paradox of the war is therefore this: even if Russia achieves tactical victories, at the strategic and structural levels its imperial afterglow is irreversibly sliding into decline. As a traditional security pivot in Eurasia, Russia is being pushed—by its own geopolitical expansion impulse and by structural economic-institutional disadvantages—into a multi-layered collapse of geopolitical

influence. This also indicates that Eurasia's future order will be reorganized around a Russia that is "declining but not collapsing," generating new multipolar realignments and intensified strategic competition among surrounding powers.

The "Power Vacuum" in the Caucasus and Central Asia: Multilateral Interventions by China, Türkiye, and the West

One of the largest spillover effects of the Russia–Ukraine war is the systematic weakening of Russia's influence in its traditional sphere—namely Central Asia and the Caucasus. In earlier geopolitical structures, these regions were widely seen as Russia's traditional post-Soviet sphere of influence, whether in terms of security provision, energy hub roles, or political leverage. However, as Russia's domestic economic difficulties deepen, military resources continue to be depleted, and diplomatic credibility declines sharply, its geopolitical sphere is being eroded on multiple fronts, forming a characteristic "influence vacuum." This is not a vacuum in the absolute sense; rather, it takes the form of external actors embedding themselves while local states actively diversify their alignment options. It signals a structural shift in Eurasia from a "regionally dominated sphere of influence" toward a "multipolar, nested arena of contestation."

In Central Asia, the structure that once depended on Russian security protection and political patronage is loosening. Central Asian states are increasingly aware of the uncertainties produced by Russia's declining position in the global order and the diminishing effect of its security commitments. For example, the Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO) failed to intervene effectively in the 2022 Armenia border conflict, exposing the continued decline of the security authority of Russia-led multilateral mechanisms. This context has pushed Central Asian states to accelerate the introduction of new balancing forces to hedge against excessive concentration of dependence on Russia. China has rapidly filled the strategic space opened by Russia's retreat. Through deep embedding via the Belt and Road Initiative, China has not only become

increasingly dominant in transport infrastructure, energy pipelines, and regional digital platform construction, but has also normalized its institutional influence through mechanisms such as the “China–Central Asia Summit” and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) (Gusseinov, 2025). This influence is not simply economic projection or collective security; it reflects an embedded governance model that integrates economics and security. China’s involvement has altered the previous model of region-wide cooperation driven primarily by security, producing a marked tilt among Central Asian states toward “rebalancing” strategies aligned with China in agenda-setting and policy choices.

At the same time, the operational logic of the SCO is also showing a tendency toward “de-Russia-centrization.” Although Russia remains one of its founding members, China’s role has become increasingly prominent in agenda leadership, institutional construction, and regional coordination (Gürçan, 2020). In areas such as counterterrorism, cybersecurity, and cross-border infrastructure coordination, more Central Asian states are willing to accept Chinese standards and rule frameworks. This organizational reconfiguration further weakens Russia’s institutional control over Central Asia and suggests that the region’s future institutional choices will lean more toward diversified balancing cooperation rather than traditional subordinate security dependence on Russia (Tüfekçi, 2024).

In the South Caucasus, the restructuring has been even more dramatic. In recent years, Azerbaijan’s military victory in the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict not only signaled a strategic rejection of Russia’s role as a neutral mediator, but also pushed Azerbaijan toward deeper military cooperation with Türkiye on security issues. A late-2024 incident in which a passenger aircraft was shot down by Russia further intensified tensions between Azerbaijan and Russia. Georgia, meanwhile, continues to advance a “de-Russification” process, seeking to consolidate its Western integration trajectory through mechanisms such as the EU and NATO. In addition, the active intervention of “secondary powers” such as Türkiye and India further intensifies the fragmentation of regional power.

Türkiye strengthens cultural linkages in Central Asia and the Caucasus through pan-Turkism. India, through energy investment and educational diplomacy, is gradually building presence in Central Asia. These states are not seeking traditional spheres of influence; rather, they are pursuing issue- and sector-specific influence narratives for regional-power standing within multipolarity. Under this structure, regional states are no longer passively subordinate to a single hegemon; instead, they actively construct multilateral choice portfolios, strategically diversifying external dependence.

Overall, Central Asia and the Caucasus are undergoing a deep paradigmatic shift. The post-Soviet sphere once dominated by Russia is being replaced by the intersecting embedding of multiple external forces, while regional states are being emancipated from the traditional role of “those being governed” and are becoming active strategists pursuing autonomy and multilateral balancing. This shift not only marks Russia’s structural decline at the center of Eurasia, but also introduces more variables and uncertainty into the construction of the future Eurasian order. It may facilitate new paradigms of multilateral cooperation, yet it may also intensify geopolitical competition through power fragmentation and increase the risk of localized conflicts.

NATO’s Further Eastward “Strategic Reach”: Extending from the Black Sea and the Baltic to the Caspian

NATO’s continued eastward expansion is one of the most structural developments in Eurasia’s postwar geopolitical transformation. This trend is not only reflected in the addition of members in the traditional sense—such as the rapid accession of Sweden and Finland—but more profoundly indicates that the Western collective security architecture is shifting from a defensive alliance to a forward-deterrence posture. NATO is gradually moving beyond its post-Cold War hesitancy toward the security demands of peripheral states, bringing countries once considered marginal or in-between into a more strategically forward security trajectory. This evolution will

have far-reaching implications for Eurasia's security boundaries and the structure of regional order.

The accession processes of Sweden and Finland carry both symbolic and substantive significance. Symbolically, they break the persistence of the post-Cold War Nordic neutrality model, indicating that the strategic cost of neutrality in the face of systemic threats has become unsustainable. Geopolitically, through the accession of Sweden and Finland, NATO has effectively sealed the Baltic Sea's geostrategic corridors and achieved comprehensive coverage along Russia's northwestern strategic frontier. This shift substantially enhances NATO's deployment capacity across the Arctic passages, the Baltic littoral, and the Nordic security space, while indirectly intensifying Russia's security vulnerability in that region.

In Southeastern Europe and the Caucasus, NATO's strategic positioning is increasingly extending along Eurasian security-corridor lines. The Black Sea-Caspian security axis is gradually becoming a key focus for building its forward deterrence system. For example, Montenegro's accession and the strengthened NATO military presence around Serbia aim to integrate the Balkans as a stable southern European pivot for NATO. The issue of Georgia's accession has re-emerged in the post-Russia-Ukraine war context; while political conditions remain complex, Georgia's candidate status and increasingly close military cooperation with NATO have effectively embedded it within the NATO security architecture (Gureshidze & Latsabidze, 2024). This trend suggests that amid Russia's declining capacity and constrained diplomatic resources, the West is more inclined to pursue practical strategic expansion rather than a passive security-guarantee posture—continually enlarging NATO's security boundaries.

NATO's forward-looking strategy in the Balkans also represents a systemic adjustment to anticipated geopolitical trends. Corridors running from the Black Sea through the South Caucasus and onward to Central Asia via the Caspian are being redefined as a new continental bridge hub linking Europe and the Indo-Pacific. By strengthening security coordination with countries such as Türkiye, Azerbaijan, and Romania, NATO aims to build a cross-Eurasian

regional deterrence chain that limits the future strategic access of China and Russia in this space. This is not simple military expansion; it is a remolding of the geopolitical security structure, reflecting a clear trend toward functionalized forward deployment.

In sum, NATO's eastward extension is not merely an expansion of military borders, but a fundamental adjustment of the post-Cold War logic of security governance. It reflects not only Russia's structural decline in geopolitical influence, but also the evolution of the Western collective security system toward a complex security posture combining multi-dimensional deterrence with spatial linkage. This process will have long-term effects on Eurasia's geopolitical stability: it increases the complexity of regional states' strategic options and may, in the absence of stable supporting mechanisms, generate a new round of security dilemmas and power frictions.

Conclusion: Eurasia's Future Trajectory Under a Multipolar Configuration

Against the backdrop of accelerating multipolarity, the Eurasian continent—one of the most geopolitically strategic spaces on earth—is shifting from the relatively clear post-Cold War unipolar-bipolar power configuration toward a multipolar order characterized by “nested power structures.” This new configuration is not simply a balanced coexistence of multiple poles; at the regional level it is manifested as deep interweaving and spatial competition among four major power centers: China, the United States, Russia, and Europe. As a result, Eurasia is entering a process of role ambiguity: it could become a geopolitical buffer zone in which multipolar forces achieve equilibrium through institutional coordination and mutual checks; or it could evolve into a collision zone, where power penetration and blurred strategic boundaries continuously generate regional security frictions and proxy conflicts.

The paradox of this multipolar configuration is that theoretical expectations of balance often fail to translate into practical, stable logics of regional governance. Apparent pluralization of power and mutual constraints does not automatically produce institutional trust

among major powers; instead, in practice they often catalyze more strategic friction. On the one hand, different country groupings across Eurasia lack deep compatibility in institutional logics and normative systems—for example, the EU’s democratic rule-of-law governance model offers limited room for coordination with China’s infrastructure-led cooperation frameworks. On the other hand, major powers’ strategic deployments in the region frequently overlap—for instance, friction between NATO’s eastward expansion and China’s Belt and Road in Central and Eastern Europe and the Caucasus becomes a potential hotspot for security competition and strategic miscalculation.

At the same time, regional states commonly adopt “multi-vector policies” to enhance autonomy within a multipolar system. Countries such as Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan not only strengthen economic and security cooperation with China, but also maintain military-framework ties with Russia and actively connect with EU technological cooperation and U.S. security dialogues. Such hedging neutrality can indeed increase small states’ strategic maneuverability, but it also greatly raises the complexity of regional strategic games. When cognitive gaps or institutional frictions emerge among external actors, states located at the intersection of power flows often become the first carriers of “proxy pressure,” leaving Eurasia in a highly unstable and fragile structure within multipolar balancing.

Moreover, institutional frictions under multipolarity are particularly acute in key domains. For example, control over energy corridors has become a focal point of structural competition among China and Russia on the one side and the EU and the United States on the other, while the construction of export pipeline networks in the Caucasus and Central Asia displays strong geopolitical conflict in the tug-of-war between “eastward” and “westward” routes. Overall, Eurasia under a multipolar configuration is unlikely to become a stable space of geopolitical reconciliation; it is more like a “strategic collision belt” continually undergoing reorganization. Multipolarity ought, in principle, to bring greater regional autonomy and cooperation opportunities. Yet under conditions of institutional asymmetry,

differentiated security priorities, strategic-cultural divergence, and persistent external intervention, it may instead intensify tension and conflict. This heightened uncertainty will be a defining feature of Eurasia in the multipolar era, posing higher requirements for institutional coordination and strategic communication in building future regional governance mechanisms.

Therefore, understanding and responding to geopolitical change amid the restructuring of power across Eurasia has become one of the most urgent and critical strategic tasks in contemporary international relations. Multipolarity is not only a challenge to the traditional international order; it is also a decisive factor shaping the future architecture of global governance and regional security. In facing this new reality, the international community must strengthen strategic communication and innovate mechanisms to reduce risks of miscalculation and conflict, and to jointly explore a path toward peaceful and stable multipolar coexistence.

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Corresponding Author Biography

Li Zhengdong (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0009-3414-7944>) received his PhD from the Ruhr University Bochum in 2016. He is currently an Associate Research Fellow at the Institute for Central and Eastern European Economic and Trade Cooperation. His research focuses on geopolitics, German studies, and industrial history.

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The United States in the Eastern Mediterranean

STRATEGIC LANDSCAPE ANALYSIS
OF ENERGY DIPLOMACY, SECURITY
POLITICS, AND ALIGNMENT SHIFTS

Sina Kısacık & Erineç Bayrı

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Abstract

Amid intensifying great-power rivalry and the growing geo-economic centrality of energy corridors, the Eastern Mediterranean has re-emerged as a pivotal arena of strategic contestation in the post-Cold War order. Against this backdrop, this study asks: How has U.S. policy shaped the evolving energy and security dynamics of the Eastern Mediterranean since the 2000s, and what has this meant for regional alignments—particularly with regard to Türkiye—and for competition with Russia and China? By addressing this question, the study seeks to assess not only Washington's strategic objectives and policy instruments, but also the broader implications of its engagement for regional order and great-power rivalry, using strategic landscape analysis as the guiding methodological framework along with case study and secondary resources. The findings indicate that U.S. policy has reshaped the Eastern Mediterranean's energy and security landscape primarily through security partnerships, legislative

initiatives, and calibrated military engagement rather than direct energy dependence. By strengthening ties with Greece, the Republic of Cyprus, Israel, and Egypt, Washington has contributed to the consolidation of new regional alignments, while its strained relations with Türkiye—amid maritime disputes, defense tensions, and Syria policy divergences—have encouraged Ankara’s more autonomous and at times Russia-leaning posture. Simultaneously, U.S. efforts to counter Russian military entrenchment and limit China’s infrastructural and technological expansion have embedded the region more deeply within broader patterns of great-power competition, transforming the regional, if not global, energy security order.

Keywords

Eastern Mediterranean; energy security; great-power competition; maritime disputes; strategic landscape analysis

Introduction

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, the United States sought to consolidate and expand its influence in the Mediterranean region through a combination of hard and soft power instruments. Lately, the discovery of substantial hydrocarbon reserves in the Eastern Mediterranean, coupled with the upheavals triggered by the Arab uprisings across the Middle East and North Africa, has elevated the strategic importance of the region in US geostrategy. At the same time, both regional and extra-regional powers—including Russia and China—have intensified their engagement, employing a range of diplomatic, economic, and military tools.

Against this backdrop, this study asks: How has U.S. policy shaped the evolving energy and security dynamics of the Eastern Mediterranean since the 2000s, and what has this meant for regional alignments—particularly with regard to Türkiye—and for competition with Russia and China? By addressing this question, the study seeks to assess not only Washington’s strategic objectives and policy instruments, but also the broader implications of its engagement for regional order and great-power rivalry, using strategic landscape analysis as the guiding methodological framework along-

side case study methodology and secondary sources. Strategic landscape analysis examines how an actor operates within a structured environment composed of political, security, economic, regulatory, technological, and institutional dimensions. Rather than treating policy decisions as isolated events, the method maps the broader strategic environment, identifies the key actors within it, analyzes how different structural layers interact, and assesses how these interactions generate shifts in alignment patterns. It emphasizes systematic environmental mapping, interconnections across domains, and the translation of structural developments into strategic positioning and realignment (Wright, 2022).

In applying this method, the study proceeds in three stages. First, it defines the evolving strategic landscape of the Eastern Mediterranean by examining structural drivers such as hydrocarbon discoveries, maritime jurisdiction disputes, institutional initiatives like the Eastern Mediterranean Gas Forum (EMGF), U.S. legislative measures (e.g., the Eastern Mediterranean Security and Energy Partnership Act), and the region's role as a geopolitical transit hub. Second, it maps how U.S. policy instruments—defense cooperation with Greece and Cyprus, security guarantees for Israel, selective engagement with Egypt, sanctions and arms decisions, and efforts to limit Russian and Chinese influence—have interacted with the strategic choices of other actors. Third, it evaluates the alignment consequences of these interactions, showing how U.S.-led coalition-building has reinforced certain regional blocs while contributing to Türkiye's strategic hedging and to increased Russian and Chinese penetration. Through this structured landscape mapping, the empirical analysis demonstrates how U.S. engagement has not only shaped the region's energy security order but also reconfigured patterns of cooperation and rivalry within an increasingly multipolar environment.

Within this framework, this article is structured in three sections. The first section examines the geopolitical, economic, and financial dimensions of energy security in the Eastern Mediterranean, analyzing hydrocarbon discoveries, maritime disputes, transit routes, and the strategic positioning of key regional actors. The second

section explores U.S. policies toward selected regional states, assessing how Washington's security partnerships, legislative initiatives, and military engagements have reshaped regional alignments and energy dynamics. The third section evaluates U.S. engagement vis-à-vis outer-regional powers, particularly Russia and China, highlighting how great-power competition has deepened multipolar contestation in the Eastern Mediterranean.

Energy Diplomacy in the Eastern Mediterranean: Geopolitical, Economic, and Financial Dimensions

The energy politics of the Eastern Mediterranean, home to one of the prominent gas fields discovered in recent years, constitutes a highly strategic area in shaping economic and political balances (Gürcan, 2019). These fields are mostly concentrated around Cyprus, Egypt, and Israel, a concentration that establishes a crucial transit corridor between Europe and Asia and positions the region as one of the most important energy routes.

Geopolitical location is regarded as a significant factor influencing the demographic, political, economic, and even financial structures of states, regions, continents, and military zones. It plays a decisive role in shaping national economies, structuring trade relations and import–export agreements, influencing political conflicts and diplomatic negotiations, and even intensifying clashes of interest—alongside states' economic and military capabilities. In countries of strategic geopolitical importance, such as Türkiye, various political, economic, and security pressures are often employed in attempts to undermine or neutralize their locational advantages. These include terrorist incidents, economic pressure, and political isolation strategies. Today, a region of critical geopolitical value such as the Eastern Mediterranean is undergoing a process of reshaping within the international arena, resulting not only in the involvement of regional states but also in the growing desire of external powers to exert influence (Stergiou, 2023; Gürcan, 2021).

Türkiye, benefiting from the advantages of its geopolitical posi-

tion, is both one of the most critical transit hubs and one of the key actors within the Eastern Mediterranean energy corridor. This country provides the shortest, most reliable, and most cost-effective route for energy transfer to European states, serving as a crucial bridge to the European market. However, Türkiye's disputes with the Republic of Cyprus (RoC), Greece, and the European Union over maritime jurisdiction areas restrict its potential and frequently bring energy diplomacy to the forefront. Recently, Türkiye has signed a bilateral agreement with the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus (TRNC) and initiated energy exploration activities in the region. This development has repeatedly triggered disputes between Türkiye, Greece, and the Greek Cypriot Administration. Although at times the possibility of energy agreements with Egypt and Israel has been raised, ongoing instability and political dilemmas have postponed such prospects. Nonetheless, owing to its geopolitical significance as a bridge between Asia and Europe, and considering the issues of energy security and cost, Türkiye is expected in the long run to become one of the most important partners for European Union member states (Lavezzo, 2025).

In the RoC, the Aphrodite, Calypso, and Glaucus fields are frequently brought to the forefront, and due to the southern part of the island being an EU member, they are regarded as alternative energy sources particularly for EU countries. The RoC, especially under the shadow of conflicts of interest and diplomatic crises with the TRNC and Türkiye, seeks to portray its energy resources as a diplomatic advantage in order to further strengthen its relations with EU member states. However, the declarations by both Türkiye and the TRNC that they will not relinquish their legitimate rights and interests in the northern part of Cyprus obstruct the RoC's attempts to exploit regional energy resources, both through diplomatic means and, when deemed necessary, through military channels. This situation, overshadowed by the ongoing disputes among the relevant states, leaves unresolved the question of which route will be used to transport Cypriot gas. While the EastMed pipeline remains contentious due to financial and technical challenges, Egypt's LNG

facilities are considered a more feasible short-term alternative (İpek, 2025).

Egypt has emerged as one of the most significant regional actors thanks to the discovery of the massive Zohr gas field. The country's most prominent LNG facilities, Idku and Damietta, have enabled Egypt to position itself in the international arena as both a producer and an exporter within the energy sector. Furthermore, by hosting the headquarters of the Eastern Mediterranean Gas Forum (EMGF), Egypt has assumed not only economic and financial roles in the energy domain but also political and diplomatic ones. At present, Egypt aims to enhance its diplomatic and bilateral relations with Israel, Cyprus, Greece, and EU countries by leveraging the energy sector, while simultaneously seeking to strengthen its foreign exchange reserves and achieve economic growth through the advantages derived from energy revenues. In addition, Egypt endeavors to meet its steadily growing domestic energy demand from its own resources (Giuli, 2021).

One of the significant energy resources in the Eastern Mediterranean region is controlled by Israel. Particularly, the Tamar and Leviathan energy fields have made Israel one of the key energy actors in the region. By increasing its production capacity, Israel seeks first to meet domestic energy demand and subsequently to position itself among the energy-exporting countries. At present, Israel exports LNG to EU countries through Egypt, while also holding the potential to transfer energy via pipelines to Jordan and Egypt. Taking advantage of the tensions and disputes over gas supply disruptions between the EU and Russia, Israel aims to establish itself as an important alternative gas supplier for the EU. Although the idea of constructing a gas pipeline through Türkiye is considered a long-term economic option, the diplomatic uncertainties between the two countries currently prevent the realization of this project (Tüysüzoğlu, 2024; Eminel-Sülün, 2025).

Another country on the map is Lebanon. Struggling with economic and financial difficulties, Lebanon has faced challenges in developing its potential hydrocarbon resources, particularly due to disputes with Israel over maritime jurisdiction. These disagreements

were resolved in 2022 through U.S. mediation, which enabled international energy companies to sign cooperation agreements with Lebanon and initiate offshore exploration activities. While energy revenues are seen as a crucial factor for Lebanon in addressing its economic crises, political uncertainties may delay the country's ability to benefit from these revenues in the short term (Yorulmaz & Kısacık, 2022).

As noted above, in an effort to prevent diplomatic crises stemming from maritime jurisdiction disputes among Eastern Mediterranean states, countries have pursued bilateral maritime boundary agreements. However, since the distance between the coasts of countries in the region does not exceed 400 nautical miles, an Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) of 200 nautical miles, as stipulated under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, is not feasible. Following the agreement signed between the Republic of Cyprus (RoC) and Egypt in February 2003, Türkiye rejected and did not recognize the treaty, as it disregarded the rights of Turkish Cypriots and treated the island as if it solely belonged to the RoC. Türkiye has also declared that its own maritime jurisdiction areas which are being violated. Furthermore, the RoC has signed maritime delimitation agreements with Lebanon in 2007 and with Israel in 2010, both of which escalated EEZ-related disputes. The Cyprus issue is regarded as the underlying factor behind these agreements. The process, which began in 1963 with the violation of Turkish Cypriots' constitutional rights by Greek Cypriots, continues today with the division of the island into two parts and the lack of mutual recognition between the North and the South in the international arena. Moreover, platforms such as the United Nations (UN) and the European Union (EU) continue to regard the island as a single entity and recognize only the RoC as the official authority, which remains a key source of disputes between Türkiye and the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus (TRNC) (Kökyay, 2021).

Today, the Eastern Mediterranean constitutes a significant commercial region of such scale that it enhances the strategic depth of the Suez Canal. As previously noted, this situation renders the region a focal point of attraction not only for the littoral states but

also for major global energy actors such as the United States, Russia, China, and even the European Union. This importance is not confined to the region's geopolitical position but also encompasses its economic, financial, trade, and political significance.

The region, by virtue of the Suez Canal serving as a link between the Mediterranean and the Red Sea, has become an appealing hub for ensuring safe, rapid, and cost-efficient trade between Asia and Europe. With the expansion of the Suez Canal, trade volume has nearly doubled, and transit times have been significantly reduced. Today, the Eastern Mediterranean constitutes a crucial center of trade circulation: it connects to the Black Sea via the Turkish Straits, to the Western Mediterranean and the Atlantic Ocean through the Strait of Sicily and the Strait of Messina, and to the Indian Ocean and the Red Sea through the Suez Canal. As such, the Eastern Mediterranean also occupies a vital geopolitical position, bridging the Middle East, North Africa, and the Balkans (Şeker, 2018).

At present, in the Eastern Mediterranean region, projects concerning the efficient and effective utilization of financial resources throughout all stages—from the exploration of potential gas reserves to their processing and integration into international markets—frequently come to the fore. From the discovery of natural gas resources to their production and export, joint projects aimed at enhancing profitability are also being discussed among states. The establishment, storage, and cross-border transfer of power plants, liquefied natural gas (LNG) facilities, and compressed natural gas (CNG) plants are expected to contribute significantly to national economies (Kökyay, 2021).

Energy serves not only as a means of establishing diplomatic relations but also as an instrument in the formation of energy diplomacy itself. Energy discoveries act as decisive factors in shaping political and economic relations. The discoveries made in the Eastern Mediterranean substantially influence the trajectory of the region's economic and political climate. Exploration activities and energy discoveries in this area may either heighten or ease tensions among countries. Foreign direct investments by leading energy firms

can exert positive effects on national economies. However, in regions marked by political uncertainty and conflict, major energy companies refrain from investing, and banks face considerable difficulty in providing financing (Kansu, 2019).

Assuming that the fundamental philosophy of companies in the global economic order is sustainable profitability, it appears inevitable that major energy investors will refrain from regions experiencing political instability. Nevertheless, in certain cases, the notion of maximizing interests through joint economic cooperation may help to resolve political instabilities. However, when examining the current landscape, it becomes evident that the establishment of energy cooperation and the alignment of economic interests on a common ground do not always provide an absolute guarantee for peace. In the Eastern Mediterranean region today, disputes over Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZ) and energy exploration activities, in particular, have at times escalated tensions among regional states, thereby frequently bringing energy diplomacy to the forefront. It is evident that the Eastern Mediterranean will continue to be an important hub not only for the littoral states but also for countries seeking to monopolize the energy market within the capitalist system.

U.S. Strategy in the Eastern Mediterranean and Its Engagement with Regional Actors

During the Cold War, Washington had seen the Eastern Mediterranean as a strategic pivot, as the area was a vital fragment of the broader Mediterranean (Dalacoura, 2018). Yet, after the Cold War, as the U.S. has acquired energy independence thanks to the advancement of shale gas and oil, the calculated standing of the Mediterranean (and the Eastern Mediterranean as component of it) for the U.S. has diminished. U.S. strategic attention has increasingly shifted toward containing China's rise, with the Asia-Pacific now serving as a primary focus of Washington's foreign policy. The 2017 U.S. National Security Strategy identifies China and Russia as the primary strategic competitors challenging American power, influ-

ence, and interests, and seeking to undermine U.S. security and prosperity (Demir, 2024a; Demir, 2024b).

This being said, the 2017 National Security Strategy of the United States of America states that “*the United States seeks a Mediterranean that does not serve as a safe haven or strategic base for jihadist terrorists, is not dominated by any power hostile to the U.S., and contributes to a stable global energy market*” (The President of the United States, 2017, p. 48). Therefore, the U.S. pivot to Asia does not automatically imply a U.S. retrenchment from the Eastern Mediterranean. The U.S. sustains close bonds with its local partners and stays involved within the area, nonetheless more indirectly as compared with the past. Egypt, Greece, Israel, and Türkiye remain crucial partners of the U.S. within the Eastern Mediterranean. Israel’s safety stands the outmost U.S. concern, whereas Greece and Türkiye stand NATO partners holding durable consensual bonds with the U.S. While Washington has narrowed its dependence on hard power instruments in this geography, the U.S. Sixth Fleet is still active within the Eastern Mediterranean. The U.S. Eastern Mediterranean forces have been reinforced in an answer to the conflict that followed Hamas’s attack towards Israel as of October 2023 (Kocadal, 2025).

At the end of December 2020, Washington has approved the bipartisan Eastern Mediterranean Security and Energy Partnership Act (US Senate Foreign Relations Committee, 2019), eliminating the limitations concerning the exportation of non-lethal security equipment to Southern Nicosia (SN) annually, and partially abandoned more than three-decade weapons’ sales prohibition (Miller, 2023), while establishing an Energy Centre with the intention of furthering cooperation with Athens and Southern Nicosia (Kontos & Georgiou, 2023). Moreover, the U.S. has also committed to providing International Military Education and Training on the way to the Greek Cypriot Administration of the Republic of Cyprus (U.S. Department of Energy, 2020). 70 OH-58D Kiowa Warrior inspection helicopters and one CH-47 Chinook helicopter from Washington were to be procured by Athens within the first months of 2019 (Valine, 2019; Global Defense News Army Recognition Group, 2017). In return, the U.S. has been able to get an armed

facility from Greek side in Alexandroupolis, almost 50 kilometers from Türkiye via an armed arrangement signed at the end of 2021 (King, 2024). Additionally, Washington has agreed to export 4 mint frigates totaling nearly 7 billion US dollars, accompanied by frigate-upgrading mission towards Greek Navy amounting to more than 2 billion US Dollars in 2021 (Hill, 2024). Meanwhile, Türkiye has requested from the U.S. to reevaluate its fractional abandoning of the arms embargo on the Greek Cypriot Administration of the Republic of Cyprus, cautioning that this might alter “equivalence and steadiness” between the Turkish and Greek Cypriots (Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2023). As stipulated in H.R. 1865—the Further Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2020—the U.S. Congress lifted the arms embargo imposed on the Republic of Cyprus in 1987, a decision that was strongly criticized by the TRNC and Türkiye (Örmeci & Kısacık, 2020).

U.S. military and political support, coupled with the perception that Washington disregards Türkiye’s security concerns and regional interests while favoring the PYD/YPG—an offshoot of the PKK, which Türkiye designates as a terrorist organization—over its NATO ally, has negatively affected the United States’ public image in Türkiye. Accordingly, while the United States and other Western countries have strongly opposed Türkiye’s military operations in northern Syria (Sarı-Karademir, 2019), Russia—despite controlling much of the airspace—has largely refrained from direct intervention. Ankara has coordinated with Moscow and Tehran through the Astana and Sochi processes to delineate areas of control in northern Syria, despite their broader support for the Syrian government differing from Türkiye’s position (Tüysüzöğlu, 2025).

Following 1979, Türkiye had emerged as Israel’s principal non-Arab regional counterpart within the framework of U.S. Middle East strategy, a role previously associated with Iran (Ghariani, 2023). However, the United States and Israel designate Hamas as a terrorist organization, whereas successive AK Party governments in Türkiye have described Hamas as the legitimate, democratically elected representative of the Palestinians. Israel’s use of force against Palestinians and the status of Jerusalem remain deeply

contentious issues between Ankara and Tel Aviv. Türkiye does not recognize Jerusalem as Israel's capital and maintains that the city's status should be resolved within the framework of a final settlement to the Israeli–Palestinian conflict, with Jerusalem serving as the capital of both states. This position commands broad public support in Türkiye and represents a significant political and symbolic threshold in bilateral relations (Shakovskaya et al., 2023).

In March 2013, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu formally apologized for the 2010 Gaza flotilla incident, and in December 2016 the two countries reached a normalization agreement, which was subsequently approved by both parliaments. Under this agreement, Israel allowed Türkiye to implement humanitarian projects in the Gaza Strip and agreed to pay \$20 million in compensation to the families of those killed and injured in the raid, leading to the restoration of diplomatic relations and the reappointment of ambassadors. However, in May 2018, Israeli forces opened fire on Palestinian protesters in Gaza following the U.S. decision to relocate its embassy to Jerusalem. In response, Turkish President Erdoğan described Israel as a “terrorist state.” Progress in the Israeli–Palestinian peace process remains essential for stabilizing Turkish–Israeli relations (Erdoğan-Şafak, 2024).

Beyond Turkish–Israeli tensions, disputes between Türkiye and Greece have constituted another major axis of instability in the Eastern Mediterranean. Tensions have intensified due to the absence of a comprehensive maritime delimitation agreement between Greece and Türkiye in the Aegean and the Eastern Mediterranean. The failure of the 2017 Crans-Montana talks further increased the risk of spillover escalation. Ankara subsequently adopted a more rigid stance, rejecting negotiation frameworks based on the UN's vision of political equality between the two communities and territorial arrangements on Cyprus. It has supported Turkish Cypriot leader Ersin Tatar, who advocates a two-state solution, and has partially reopened Varosha, a coastal district of Famagusta that has remained under Turkish military control since the 1970s. These developments have unfolded alongside the deterioration of U.S.–Türkiye relations, reducing prospects for

compromise and increasing the likelihood of confrontation. The discovery of hydrocarbon resources, which could have incentivized cooperation, instead exacerbated disputes over maritime boundaries, energy exploration, and pipeline routes, encouraging zero-sum strategies. In this context, the Cyprus–Greece–Egypt and Cyprus–Greece–Israel alignments have evolved into *de facto* counterbalancing groupings against Türkiye, reinforcing Greek confidence while heightening Turkish threat perceptions (Şahin, 2024).

By August 2020, U.S. Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs David Hale argued that the development of Eastern Mediterranean hydrocarbons would “guarantee long-term energy security and economic prosperity across the region” (Kocadal, 2025). However, in April 2022, then–Under Secretary of State Victoria Nuland expressed skepticism toward the proposed EastMed pipeline, describing it as economically and technically unviable. The U.S. withdrawal of support for EastMed increased the strategic relevance of the proposed Israel–Türkiye Pipeline (ITP) as a more feasible alternative for transporting gas from Israel and Cyprus to Europe. Estimated at roughly \$2 billion—less than half the projected cost of EastMed—the ITP could connect to the Trans-Anatolian Natural Gas Pipeline (TANAP), facilitating onward transmission to European markets. Nevertheless, strained Türkiye–Israel relations, particularly in the context of the Gaza conflict, have hindered progress on this option (Kocadal, 2025).

Finally, disputes over maritime jurisdiction and drilling activities around Cyprus have further escalated tensions between Türkiye and the EU–U.S. axis. Ankara has rejected the EU-backed Seville Map on the grounds that it reflects maximalist Greek claims and infringes upon Turkish maritime rights. In response, Türkiye signed a maritime delimitation agreement with Libya’s interim government, directly challenging Greek interpretations of maritime boundaries. Consistent with the “Blue Homeland” doctrine (Gürçan, 2021), Türkiye has opposed drilling licenses granted by the Republic of Cyprus in areas it considers to fall within its own continental shelf and has issued NAVTEX notices while deploying drilling vessels and naval escorts to assert its claims. The exclusion of Türkiye from the

Eastern Mediterranean Gas Forum (EMGF) and the EastMed pipeline initiative has further reinforced Ankara's perception of encirclement. While Türkiye has pursued assertive policies to defend its interests, it has also demonstrated a capacity to de-escalate—suspending drilling activities, withdrawing naval assets from contested areas, and re-engaging diplomatically with Athens—when broader strategic considerations require it (Tüysüzöğlu, 2025).

In sum, U.S. engagement with the Eastern Mediterranean reflects neither full retrenchment nor unqualified dominance, but rather a calibrated strategy designed to preserve influence amid shifting regional and global dynamics. By deepening security cooperation with Greece, the Republic of Cyprus, and Israel while maintaining strategic ties with Egypt, Washington has reinforced a networked alignment structure that both stabilizes certain partnerships and intensifies friction with Türkiye. Legislative initiatives, defense agreements, and selective military deployments demonstrate that the United States continues to view the region through a security-centered lens, even as its broader strategic focus pivots toward great-power competition with China and Russia. Yet this approach has produced unintended consequences: it has contributed to Türkiye's strategic hedging behavior, complicated alliance cohesion within NATO, and embedded Eastern Mediterranean energy diplomacy within a wider framework of geopolitical rivalry. Rather than functioning solely as a zone of energy cooperation, the region has increasingly become a testing ground for competing security visions and alignment configurations.

U.S. Policy in the Eastern Mediterranean: Engagement with Extra-Regional Powers

The Syrian conflict (2011-2025) has evolved into a key arena in the Eastern Mediterranean where Russia and the United States have competed for influence while occasionally being compelled to coordinate. Since Russia's military intervention in Syria in 2015, Moscow has significantly expanded its presence, whereas the United States has primarily focused on countering ISIS through local oppo-

sition forces. Cooperation between Russia and the U.S. has remained limited, largely confined to deconfliction mechanisms and coordination over airspace use in counterterrorism operations. However, the reconfiguration of the regional landscape following the partial withdrawal of U.S. forces in 2019 enabled Russia to further consolidate its influence in Syria. This arrangement remains fragile, given the presence of U.S.-backed Kurdish forces and Türkiye's military operations in northern Syria, which complicate the strategic calculations of both major powers (İnaç & Kına, 2025).

Türkiye's rapprochement with Russia over the past decade can partly be understood as an attempt to balance between Russia and the West in an increasingly multipolar international system. The failed coup attempt in July 2016 marked a turning point, accelerating Ankara's closer engagement with Moscow. Russia's swift and explicit support for the Turkish government during the coup attempt—combined with Ankara's suspicions regarding U.S. involvement—encouraged Türkiye to deepen ties with Russia, particularly in the interest of regime security. Moscow, in turn, provided political backing during Erdoğan's 2023 presidential and parliamentary election campaign. Despite remaining a NATO member and benefiting from alliance security guarantees, Türkiye's growing closeness to Russia strained its relations with traditional Western partners. Notably, Türkiye's 2017 decision to purchase the Russian S-400 air defense system led to its removal from the U.S. F-35 program and the imposition of CAATSA sanctions in 2020. As a result, Türkiye—despite being a NATO member—was placed under sanctions alongside Russia, China, North Korea, and Iran. Although Türkiye's approval of Sweden's NATO membership in January 2024 paved the way for U.S. approval of F-16 sales to Ankara, this move was offset by Washington's parallel expansion of F-35 sales to Greece. Originally, Türkiye had planned to acquire nearly 100 F-35 aircraft to modernize its air force. The deterioration of U.S.–Türkiye relations has extended beyond defense procurement, also resulting in Türkiye's exclusion from U.S.-led multilateral initiatives such as the I2U2 Initiative, which seeks to enhance economic integration across the Middle East and beyond. This

strain has contributed to a closer U.S. alignment with Greece and Cyprus in the Eastern Mediterranean, as reflected in the defense agreement signed between Cyprus and the United States on September 9, 2024 (Aydın-Düzgit et al., 2025).

Washington has also warned Cairo about the potential consequences of acquiring Russia's Sukhoi-35 multi-role fighter aircraft, cautioning that such a purchase could trigger CAATSA sanctions and complicate U.S. defense cooperation and security assistance to Egypt. Although Egypt initially sought to purchase 20 aircraft and reportedly received five, it ultimately reversed its decision. In return, the United States approved upgrades to Egypt's AH-64D Apache Longbow attack helicopters (Schenker & Trager, 2014; Iddon, 2021).

In parallel, China's growing interest in the Mediterranean has expanded beyond securing energy supplies, reflecting broader transformations in regional and global dynamics over the past decade. The Mediterranean has become a strategic linkage zone connecting Chinese foreign policy objectives across South Asia, Eurasia, Europe, and Africa. Within China's broader geopolitical framework, Central Asia, the Middle East, and South Asia are often conceptualized as part of a wider Western Asia space. The launch of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in 2013 further integrated the Mediterranean into China's strategic vision. Through infrastructure and transportation corridors—including the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor and the Middle Corridor involving Türkiye and Gulf states—the Mediterranean has emerged as a logistical hub in China's expanding trade network (Yüce, 2022; Gürcan, 2021).

According to China's 2016 Arab Policy Paper, Beijing's priorities in the Middle East and Mediterranean include economic cooperation, energy security, counterterrorism, regional stability, technological collaboration, and BRI implementation. China's policy framework emphasizes fossil fuel cooperation supported by infrastructure and trade, alongside future plans to expand cooperation in nuclear energy, renewable technologies, and satellite systems. Beijing has elevated its ties with several Middle Eastern states to the level of Comprehensive Strategic Partnerships and has strengthened

engagement with multilateral bodies such as the Arab League and the China–Gulf Cooperation Forum. As a result, China’s earlier “non-interventionist” or “baggage-free” diplomacy—characteristic of the 2000s—has gradually evolved into a more active and strategically engaged regional posture (Yüce, 2022).

In seeking to link the Eurasian continent from East to West, China has incorporated Iran, Türkiye, Israel, and Egypt into its BRI framework and supported Saudi Arabia’s transformation into a major logistics hub through railway and infrastructure projects. The Mediterranean, in this context, is viewed as a critical node where the “Belt” connects to the “Road.” Through strategic port investments and major infrastructure projects in countries such as Pakistan, Egypt, Türkiye, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Saudi Arabia, and Iran, China has enhanced its influence across the Eurasia–Africa–Middle East nexus (Gürel & Kozluca, 2022; Durmaz, 2025). Its deepening strategic partnership with Egypt since 2014 has significantly increased Chinese investment in the Suez Canal Economic Zone. As U.S. influence in the region shows signs of relative decline, Egypt’s expanding ties with Russia and the Eurasian Economic Union, combined with its pivotal maritime location, position China–Egypt relations within a broader framework of intensifying great-power competition (Zreik, 2024; Gülseven, 2022). Egypt and Algeria, in particular, are viewed by Beijing as “strategic pivots” capable of serving as conduits of Chinese influence across military, economic, political, and ideological domains (Güçyetmez & Kısacık, 2025).

During the first Trump administration, the United States restricted the sale of advanced semiconductor technologies to Chinese firms such as Huawei and ZTE. Washington also warned Mediterranean partners about the potential security risks associated with Huawei’s 5G infrastructure. However, the United States was unable to prevent key regional partners—including Türkiye and Egypt—from cooperating with Huawei in developing 5G networks (Kontos & Georgiou, 2023; Chenga & Zeng, 2024; Örmeci et al., 2024). The U.S. also expressed concerns about Chinese involvement in Israel’s Port of Haifa, but Israeli authorities declined Washing-

ton's proposal for direct inspections (Egozi, 2021). In response to growing Chinese economic influence, the United States has expanded its strategic presence in Greece, increasing access to bases and ports. Although enhanced U.S.–Greece security cooperation has constrained some aspects of Chinese expansion, it has not entirely displaced Chinese economic influence (Karamouzi, 2022; U.S. Embassy & Consulate in Greece, 2024). China continues to develop the Port of Piraeus as a major container hub in the Eastern Mediterranean and one of Europe's key maritime gateways. Greece, for its part, has sought to maintain balanced relations, sustaining high-level engagement with both Washington and Beijing (He, 2019).

Overall, U.S. engagement with extra-regional powers in the Eastern Mediterranean illustrates how the region has become embedded within broader patterns of great-power competition. While Washington seeks to contain Russian military entrenchment and limit China's expanding economic and technological footprint, its policies have simultaneously reshaped regional alignments and complicated relations with key actors such as Türkiye and Egypt. Russia's consolidation in Syria and China's infrastructural expansion through the Belt and Road Initiative have transformed the Eastern Mediterranean into a strategic intersection of military positioning, energy routes, and logistical corridors. In this environment, U.S. policy reflects a balancing act—aimed at preserving strategic influence without direct overextension—yet the cumulative effect has been the deepening of multipolar contestation rather than the stabilization of a clear regional order.

Conclusion

The United States has long maintained a presence in the Mediterranean. With the growing strategic significance of the Eastern Mediterranean—driven by the discovery of substantial hydrocarbon reserves and the presence of critical maritime chokepoints—the region has regained importance in U.S. strategic calculations. Israel's security, which Washington prioritizes consistently and

unequivocally, further reinforces the region's importance. To sustain its influence, the United States has employed a range of power instruments, including the deployment of naval and air assets to demonstrate its presence, diplomatic engagement, support for U.S. companies' civilian initiatives, and the formation of multilateral partnerships with key Eastern Mediterranean states. Across the broader Middle East and North Africa region, successive U.S. administrations have worked to ensure a secure strategic environment for Israel. Washington has cooperated closely with pro-Western regional allies such as Jordan and Egypt to advance these objectives. The dynamics of the recent Israel–Gaza war illustrate this pattern of alignment. While relatively few states have openly criticized Israel's large-scale military operations despite concerns regarding international law, many regional actors and observers worldwide have characterized these actions as constituting genocide.

In recent years, particularly in the context of the fight against DAESH in Syria and Iraq, Ankara and Washington have frequently found themselves at odds. Ankara maintains that it has been the only actor directly confronting DAESH on the ground, while it strongly objects to Washington's cooperation with the PYD/YPG, which Türkiye designates as an offshoot of the PKK terrorist organization. From Ankara's perspective, combating one terrorist organization by relying on another is both unethical and inconsistent with international norms, and it undermines the spirit of alliance within NATO. In contrast, the United States has supported Greece's initiatives in the Eastern Mediterranean across military and energy domains. Within this framework, Washington and Athens have expanded their cooperation, including alignment with Cairo and other regional capitals. At the same time, the United States has sought to counterbalance Türkiye's proactive foreign and energy policies, as well as its security maneuvers, while also limiting Russian political, economic, and military influence and China's growing presence—particularly through the Belt and Road Initiative—in order to preserve its strategic position in the region.

In conclusion, in order to sustain its strategic visibility and influence in the Eastern Mediterranean in the twenty-first century,

Washington continues to rely on a combination of hard and soft power tools, reinforced by coalition-building with states whose interests align with its own. Conversely, regional actors—most notably Türkiye—who perceive themselves as excluded from certain U.S.-led initiatives have sought to diversify their partnerships, strengthening ties with Libya, Syria, and Egypt while remaining receptive to Russian and Chinese engagement in the Mediterranean. Both Russia and China have established significant footholds in the region through various political, economic, and strategic initiatives, and their presence is likely to expand further. Ultimately, Washington's proactive policies in the Eastern Mediterranean are generating not only new regional alliances but also intensifying rivalries, as external powers such as Russia and China continue to shape the evolving balance of power in the region.

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Corresponding Author Biography

Sina Kısacık (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-3603-6510>) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of International Relations at the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences, Cyprus Aydın University, where he has been teaching since October 2021. Between 2020 and 2021, he lectured in the Public Law Master's Programme at the Social Sciences Institute of Özyeğin University, Türkiye. He received his PhD in Political Science and International Relations from Yeditepe University in July 2017 with a dissertation titled "The Ukraine Policy of the Russian Federation and the Paradigms in European Energy Security." He holds an MA in European Union Studies from Galatasaray University and a BA in International Relations from İstanbul Bilgi University. Dr. Kısacık has authored and co-authored several books, book chapters, and articles in national and international academic journals in both English and Turkish, focusing on energy geopolitics, Turkish foreign policy, and Eurasian geopolitics. He also serves on the editorial and academic advisory boards of the peer-reviewed journal UPA Strategic Affairs and several other academic journals.

Co-Author Biography

Erinç Bayrı (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-9019-3701>) is an Assistant Professor in Banking and Finance at Cyprus Aydın University. He holds a PhD in Finance and specializes in banking and financial systems. His research focuses on commercial lending, financial institutions, financial derivatives, banking regulation and supervision, international finance, and financial management. He also studies the structure, stability, and regulatory transformation of banking sectors in emerging and developing economies. Dr. Bayrı teaches undergraduate and graduate courses including Financial Institutions, Commercial Lending, Financial Derivatives, International Finance, Banking Regulation and Supervision, and Financial Management. In his teaching, he integrates real-world case studies, regulatory developments, and global financial market

trends. His broader academic interests include country risk premiums, financial literacy, capital flows, banking profitability, and the resilience of financial systems under macroeconomic shocks. He regularly participates in academic conferences and contributes to research projects focusing on financial system development and regulatory frameworks.

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Regulating the Absurd

'KILLER ROBOTS' AND THE MORALITY BEHIND ARMS REGULATIONS

Jan Falgueras-Riu

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Abstract

The rapid development of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS) has intensified debates over the adequacy of existing legal and ethical frameworks governing armed conflict. This article examines how the ethical concerns associated with autonomous weapons can be adequately addressed through existing legal obligations or whether they introduce novel moral challenges demanding new regulatory standards. Methodologically, the study employs qualitative content analysis of academic, legal, and policy debates concerning the regulation of LAWS, identifying and categorizing the principal moral arguments advanced in contemporary discussions. The findings reveal three broad categories of concerns: challenges related to compliance with existing IHL principles, unprecedented ethical issues arising from the autonomous exercise of lethal force, and intensified moral risks shared with other unmanned weapon systems. The article argues that, regardless of their potential legal compliance, LAWS fundamentally transform the relationship between human agency and lethal force, thereby necessitating additional normative standards centered on meaningful human control.

Keywords

artificial intelligence; autonomous weapons systems; international humanitarian law; lethal autonomous weapons systems; meaningful human control

Introduction

When studying arms regulations, one comes across apparently paradoxical legal reactions to technological developments, encountering prohibitions on blinding laser weapons for its human-blinding potential but acceptance of other weapons with human-killing performances. The advent of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS) represents one of the latest —most disruptive— military technological breakthrough and unprecedented challenges to the moral principles behind these logically problematic regulations.

In recent years, automated weapons have been developed in a soaringly unstable rearming environment and used in —ever more recurrent— armed conflicts, reducing the political and military costs for decision-makers while further distancing them from the human consequences of warfare. Technological innovations have increasingly sought greater autonomy from human intervention, ostensibly in pursuit of a form of warfare ethics grounded in technological precision and the protection of non-combatants. In doing so, they have introduced unprecedented transformations not only in the characteristics of weapons and combatants, but also in the very nature and conception of armed conflict.

This article deals with the challenges posed by fully autonomous lethal weapons systems, the most groundbreaking of these innovations. Formally named Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (United Nations [UN], 2024c), they are also labelled ‘killer robots’ (Sparrow, 2007), and defined by the United Nations Convention for Certain Conventional Weapons (UN CCW) as “an integrated combination of one or more weapons and technological components that enable the system to [...] select, and engage a target, without intervention by a human user” (UN, 2024c, p. 1). They are “human-out-of-the-loop weapons” (Docherty, 2012, p. 2), a category

that is particularly concerning due to their potential capacity to independently perform critical functions such as target identification and engagement, including the use of lethal force in anti-personnel operations without human intervention and in contexts that may not be fully known or specified in advance (Arkin et al., 2019; Barbé & Badell, 2020; Docherty, 2012; Krishnan, 2009).

In fact, that is already a realized potential, since the UN Security Council (UNSC, 2021) affirmed they were used in Libya in 2020. Notwithstanding their contemporary appearance, the surrounding debates are over a decade old. Discussions within the United Nations began in 2013 at the Human Rights Council (HRC) and, from 2014 onward, continued under the framework of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), given its established role in developing and refining norms through its protocols (Barbé & Badell, 2020; HRC, 2013; UN, 2014).

However, the specific moral concerns raised by LAWS remain insufficiently defined, as does their relationship to established normative principles and prospective legal regulation. Clearly, these systems represent not only the latest stage in technological innovation aimed at replacing the human combatant on the battlefield, but also a profound shift in the identity—and even the humanity—of the agent that exercises lethal force (Barbé & Badell, 2020; HRC, 2013). They present substantial ethical novelties that could challenge the legal structure and moral principles of International Humanitarian Law (IHL) (Sullins, 2013).

For this reason, the present study examines the normative and moral transformations associated with LAWS and their use in armed conflict, focusing on the principles and justifications advanced in debates over their regulation. It seeks to determine whether LAWS introduce moral transformations of such magnitude that they give rise to novel ethical concerns, thereby necessitating additional normative principles to complement existing obligations under international humanitarian law (IHL). Therefore, this study's contribution rests on its comprehensive analysis of all moral and legal concerns advanced by LAWS and how these both challenge traditional normative principles and conceptions of arms regula-

tions, and potentially demand expansions beyond them. Rather than positioning debated moral and legal arguments in opposition, it integrates them within a coherent analytical framework for the regulation of LAWS. As such, the study provides a comprehensive account of the moral challenges these systems pose and considers their implications for the normative governance of future technological developments.

This study is structured around three arguments. First, it highlights that arms regulation has traditionally been grounded in the normative principles of international humanitarian law (IHL) and international human rights law (IHRL), which are themselves rooted in moral and humanitarian justifications. Second, it argues that LAWS may be capable, at least in principle, of complying with IHL and its underlying moral foundations. Third, it posits that, irrespective of their uncertain capacity to comply with IHL, LAWS introduce transformations in weaponry and armed conflict so profound that they raise ethical questions about the sufficiency of traditional regulatory principles and generate new moral concerns that require additional normative standards for their regulation.

Accordingly, the remainder of this article will discuss previous literature about norms and principles on arms regulations and the main academic views around LAWS. In the subsequent section, the methodology followed will be laid out. Then, the results of the content analysis will be presented and ordered, clearly stating the moral principles gathered from debates around LAWS' regulation, which will provide three avenues: moral challenges to LAWS' compliance with IHL, unprecedented moral issues outside IHL and exacerbated moral risks shared with other unmanned weapons. Building on this framework, the findings will be examined through a critical discussion of competing perspectives, engaging the debate in a manner that ultimately supports the case for regulation grounded in meaningful human control. The conclusion will then offer additional reflections and avenues for future research on morality and war.

Literature Review: Normative Foundations of Arms Regulation and the Challenge of LAWS

Outside situations involving aggression, prohibited under the UN Charter, the use of armed force may be lawful under international law, although the right “to choose methods and means of warfare is not unlimited” (Anderberg et al., 1992, p. 287). Indeed, since the adoption of Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions from June 8 1977, based on the principles established in the Geneva Conventions of 1949 (ICRC, 1949), every weapon or military technology innovation liable to be used in armed conflict has been assessed under, and validated against, the same international parameters.

Today’s normative and legal framework about arms regulations stems from the basic principles of the international law of war (Khan et al., 2019; Watts, 2015) established in several broadly ratified treaties and conventions on *jus in bello* (McMahan, 2006). The forefather of war regulations and “laws of humanity” was the Saint Petersburg Declaration of 1868 (ICRC, 1988, para. 7). These developments were followed by the Hague Conventions of 1907, which further defined prohibited military practices (Anderberg et al., 1992; Krishnan, 2009). However, the core foundations of international humanitarian law (IHL), and the principles that continue to underpin contemporary arms regulation, were firmly established in the Geneva Conventions of 1949 and, more decisively, in Additional Protocol I of 1977 (UN, 1977). Moreover, subsequent treaties and conventions on disarmament, arms control, regulation, and prohibition have also drawn upon principles derived from international human rights law (IHRL) (Asaro, 2012; Brunet et al., 2021; Roumate, 2021).

It is pertinent to note that, despite the internationally consensual nature of many of these treaties, their creation and observance are highly conditioned by powerful states’ influence and interests, and usually involve considerable double standards (Hirst, 2002). Which weapons are regulated — and how — has largely depended on states’ interests, historically those of Western powers. Technological

innovations, particularly in weaponry, are not neutral; they are deeply shaped by existing power structures (United Nations Development Programme [UNDP], 2022). Thus, weapons and their regulations are always shaped by the norms, biases and inequalities that structure the societies within which they are created and, in this case, within which these weapons are programmed (Acheson, 2020a).

The “traditional organising principles” (Barbé & Badell, 2020, p. 145) of IHL, based on the international doctrine of civilian immunity, that were established in the Geneva Conventions of 1949 and consolidated in the Additional Protocol I of 1977, are the principle of distinction, the principle of proportionality and the principle of precaution, namely “precautions in attack” and “precautions against the effects of attacks” (UN, 1977; UN, 2023). Additionally, the Hague Conventions establish principles prohibiting weapons that cause excessive suffering or superfluous injury in relation to military advantage and necessity (Anderberg et al., 1992; Asaro, 2012). Furthermore, a provision from these conventions has crystallized into customary international law and serves as a valuable instrument for governing weapons innovations that evolve more rapidly than often reactive regulatory frameworks (Marchant et al., 2011). This is the Martens Clause, which affirms that, even in cases not covered by specific treaties, conduct remains subject to the principles of international law derived from established custom, “from the laws of humanity, and the dictates of public conscience” (Second International Peace Conference: The Hague, 1907, para. 7).

Meanwhile, a broad range of academic and institutional perspectives on LAWS converges on the view that these weapons challenge the existing international normative framework, as well as our understanding of how it operates (Boulainin & Verbruggen, 2017a; United Nations Secretary-General, 2018; Sullins, 2013). Most scholars argue that LAWS raise distinct ethical and normative concerns, particularly due to their autonomy in performing critical functions (Boulainin & Verbruggen, 2017b; Rosendorf et al., 2022; Roumate, 2021). While some consider these challenges manageable

and technically solvable (Arkin, 2009), others view them as an opportunity to rethink international law and ethics in armed conflict, orienting them more firmly toward humanitarian imperatives and human security in an increasingly technological future (Kaldor, 2020).

Even so, the literature is divided into three broad strands when assessing the normative implications of LAWS, each grounded in distinct moral arguments. Some scholars contend that, despite their innovative features as fully autonomous weapons — or precisely because of them — LAWS can comply with international humanitarian law (IHL) principles as well as, or even better than, human combatants (Burri, 2018; Marchant et al., 2011; Müller, 2016; Singer, 2009; Young, 2021). They argue that LAWS may be ethically advantageous in their capacity to select targets with greater precision (Young, 2021), to act more conservatively in the use of force (Burri, 2018), and to avoid committing war crimes such as torture or rape driven by fear, anger, or revenge (Müller, 2016). Some even suggest that autonomous systems could be programmed to incorporate forms of moral monitoring in their operational behavior (Arkin, 2009).

Other scholars share the view that LAWS could, in principle, comply with existing IHL norms and therefore cannot simply be prohibited or heavily restricted under the current legal framework. However, they maintain that LAWS raise unprecedented moral concerns that require the expansion or adaptation of IHL and the broader normative architecture governing armed conflict, potentially through the development of new or alternative principles (Rosendorf et al., 2022; Solovyeva & Hynek, 2018).

A third strand of scholarship argues that LAWS are unlikely to operate within the requirements of the law of armed conflict (Khan et al., 2019). According to this perspective, fully autonomous “killer robots” are inherently incompatible with IHL due to their lack of meaningful human involvement and judgment (Docherty, 2015; Krishnan, 2009; Sharkey, 2016). These accounts emphasize the fallibility of autonomous algorithms in applying the principles of distinction and proportionality in dynamic and unpredictable envi-

ronments (Spazian et al., 2021), and they question the methods used to calculate civilian harm, which may obscure the true extent of LAWS' compliance with the principle of distinction (Qazi & Jillani, 2012). Moreover, proponents of this view argue that compliance with IHL requires a sufficient degree of meaningful human control over the use of force (Amoroso & Tamburrini, 2020).

Interestingly, although the concept of “meaningful human control” has gained prominence in recent debates on LAWS, it was already described as an “implicit organizing principle” in earlier arms control regimes grounded in IHL (Barbé & Badell, 2020, p. 137). This was the case, for example, with chemical and biological weapons (Barbé & Badell, 2020) and with landmines (Costa, 2009).

In light of these competing perspectives and moral arguments surrounding LAWS and their regulatory prospects, the present study seeks to provide a comprehensive analysis of their moral transformations and how these interact with traditional normative principles of arms regulation, as well as with possible expansions beyond them. Its objective is to assess the normative possibilities of LAWS through an exhaustive and integrative examination of both their positive and negative moral characteristics, as articulated in academic and institutional debates. Ultimately, this study argues that, notwithstanding the potential for LAWS to exhibit capabilities that may one day surpass human performance, they represent a technological and moral turning point. As such, they are unlikely to fully comply with IHL principles and raise moral challenges that extend beyond the current scope of IHL. Consequently, LAWS require both rigorous scrutiny under existing IHL standards and the development of additional normative principles to ensure comprehensive regulation — and, above all, to formally recognize and legally codify the emerging moral principles that will shape the governance of future, even more advanced, weapons systems.

Methodological Framework: A Content Analysis of LAWS Debates

To assess the normative consequences arising from the emergence of LAWS, this study systematically compiles and examines the full range of moral arguments advanced both in support of and against these weapons. This is undertaken through a qualitative content analysis, which involves the systematic coding and categorization of recurring themes, normative claims, and argumentative patterns across the selected texts (Erdem and Özbek, 2023). Our qualitative content analysis identified three overarching thematic clusters — (1) obstacles to compliance with IHL and IHRL (including deficiencies in qualitative judgment, intent recognition, non-discrimination, and human dignity), (2) unprecedented moral challenges beyond the scope of IHL (such as automated lethal deliberation, loss of moral agency and compassion, unpredictability, and accountability gaps), and (3) exacerbated systemic risks associated with autonomous warfare (including lowered conflict thresholds, civilian burden-shifting, escalation dynamics, proliferation, and cyber vulnerability).

The following section presents a comprehensive and critical examination of discourses contained in a series of texts produced by key actors — including states and civil society organizations — that have participated in the United Nations debates on the regulation of LAWS over the past decade. The analysis begins with the first official UN meeting dedicated to LAWS — then referred to as Lethal Autonomous Robots (LARs) — and their possible regulation, held in 2013.

The study develops a structured categorization and ordered mapping of the views and moral considerations repeatedly articulated across these texts. Through discursive content analysis of these reports, it identifies the principal arguments that should inform a genuinely comprehensive and integrative debate on the regulation of LAWS. As a preliminary clarification, it is important to emphasize that the “moral principles” examined in this content analysis are not defined normatively by the author. Rather, they encompass all arguments advanced by participating actors that make claims

about what is right or wrong in a universal sense — even where such normative intent is not made explicit.

The primary sources analyzed in this study consist of official reports issued by key United Nations bodies that have hosted debates on LAWS. These include the United Nations Human Rights Council (2013) and the framework of the United Nations Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), encompassing the Informal Meetings of Experts held between 2014 and 2016 and the subsequent sessions of the Group of Governmental Experts from 2017 to 2025. In addition, the study examines reports produced by the most influential civil society organizations participating in these debates, including Human Rights Watch (Docherty, 2012; HRW, 2016), the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots (2013, 2016, 2021), and the International Committee of the Red Cross (2021).

Empirical Investigation on LAWS' Moral Challenges

As previously discussed, arms control regimes have historically been consolidated through international treaties and conventions grounded in broadly shared normative principles and moral considerations. Most of these agreements — particularly in the post-Second World War period — have been promoted, negotiated, or adopted within United Nations bodies and forums, including the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA), the Human Rights Council (HRC), and the framework of the United Nations Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW). In the case of LAWS, debates began within the HRC in 2013 but soon shifted to the CCW in 2014, given the latter's institutional structure and its protocols' potential for normative development. Delegations from all UN member states, along with numerous other representatives, participated in these discussions.

Notably, the moral challenges associated with LAWS identified within the CCW process and by the three organizations examined in this study — Human Rights Watch (HRW), the Campaign to

Stop Killer Robots (CSKR), and the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) — largely converge. Their concerns broadly fall into three overlapping categories: moral obstacles to compliance with international humanitarian law (and international human rights law), unprecedented ethical issues that extend beyond the current scope of IHL, and the intensified moral risks associated with increasingly autonomous unmanned systems.

Given this significant convergence between institutional and civil society perspectives, and in order to provide a comprehensive account of the debates surrounding LAWS, these concerns and claims will be critically examined alongside contrasting academic viewpoints, including those that adopt more permissive or skeptical positions regarding the need for stringent regulation.

Moral Obstacles to Comply with IH(R)L

Qualitative Judgment and Situational Awareness

Both the UN CCW reports and the submissions of the organizations examined express skepticism about whether fully autonomous weapons can comply with international humanitarian law (IHL) and international human rights law (IHRL). They emphasize the necessity of meaningful human judgment, control, or at least the possibility of human intervention in order for the laws of war to be respected (CSKR, 2016; Docherty, 2012; HRW, 2016; UN, 2014; UN, 2016; UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a; UN, 2021b; UN, 2023; UN, 2024a; UN, 2024b; UN, 2024c). Early reports stressed the indispensability of subjective human judgment and qualitative deliberation for compliance with the IHL principles of proportionality and precaution (CSKR, 2021b; Docherty, 2012; HRC, 2013; HRW, 2016). Later contributions further highlighted the importance of situational awareness in armed conflict contexts — a capacity considered deficient in LAWS (CSKR, 2013; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2016).

These allegedly missing features are likewise regarded in academic literature as essential for complying with the principles of

proportionality and precaution (Asaro, 2012), as well as for assessing military necessity in situations that resist precise quantification (Khan et al., 2019). By contrast, other scholars contend that LAWS do not pose a fundamental challenge to IHL (Müller, 2016), and some even argue that autonomous systems could comply more effectively than humans, given their lack of self-preservation instincts and their potential to act conservatively, applying precaution and proportionality without emotional impulse (Arkin, 2009; Burri, 2018).

Intuition, Recognition of Intent, and Discriminatory Risks

With regard to the IHL principle of distinction, UN bodies and the organizations examined identify two inherent limitations of LAWS — “intuition” (HRC, 2013, p. 10) and the human ability to interpret intentions (HRW, 2016; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2016) — as crucial for protecting civilians and vulnerable combatants. This position is echoed in academic scholarship (Zehfuss, 2011). In addition, automated algorithmic decision-making is viewed as unlikely to ensure accurate distinctions, particularly because of the risk of “amplification of discriminatory social — gender and racial — biases” embedded in data and design processes (UN, 2021b, p. 13).

Arbitrary Digital Dehumanization

Algorithmic life-and-death decision-making — seen by some as “arbitrary” (HRC, 2013, p. 7) — is described as constituting an unprecedented form of “digital dehumanisation threat” (CSKR, 2021b, para. 5). Such decision-making is regarded as incompatible with core IHRL principles, including human dignity (HRW, 2016; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2014; UN, 2016), as well as the rights to life and to a fair trial (UN, 2014; UN, 2016).

This form of non-human decision-making — unprecedented in the history of warfare — is also widely characterized in academic literature as a serious normative threat (Brunet et al., 2021; Rosendorf et al., 2022; Roumate, 2021). Nevertheless, dissenting

perspectives argue that LAWS would not necessarily undermine the dignity of combatants to a greater extent than human actors, who may themselves act in ways shaped by emotion, prejudice, or disrespect (Burri, 2018; Lim, 2019; Young, 2021).

Unprecedented Moral Issues Outside IHL

Moral Lethal Deliberation versus Automation

Beyond concerns related directly to IHL compliance, LAWS raise additional unprecedented moral challenges that are largely deontological in nature and intrinsic to their defining characteristics. Debate reports frequently argue that the automation of life-and-death decisions is ethically problematic in itself (CSKR, 2013; UN, 2014; UN, 2016; UN, 2017). Some maintain that the act of killing must remain a moral decision grounded in human deliberation, rather than a — potentially “arbitrary” (HRC, 2013, p. 7) — data-driven automated process (ICRC, 2021; UN, 2021b). This concern is amplified by claims that algorithmic decision-making may reproduce and intensify structural inequalities embedded in data systems (CSKR, 2021b; UN, 2021b).

Academic perspectives that advocate expanding regulation beyond IHL similarly regard the delegation of lethal decisions to algorithms as an intrinsic moral problem (Tegmark et al., 2021), describing it as dehumanizing, arbitrary, and discriminatory due to the amplification of social biases (Limata, 2023). By contrast, scholars who interpret the challenges of LAWS as technologically resolvable argue that human actors in armed conflict often behave arbitrarily themselves, particularly under the influence of negative emotions. From this perspective, it may be preferable for a machine to kill correctly according to legal standards than for a human to kill for the wrong reasons (Burri, 2018). Some suggest that an “ethical governor” (Arkin, 2009, p. 127) and forms of moral conditionality could be preprogrammed into algorithms (Burri, 2018), enabling autonomous systems to approximate morally reasoned decisions (Wagner, 2014). Nonetheless, others maintain that it is highly

unlikely that LAWS could perform such essential tasks as “distinguish[ing] legal from illegal orders” (HRC, 2013, p. 11).

Moral Burden and Compassion

Several reports express concern over the absence of moral and emotional burden in LAWS’ decision-making processes (CSKR, 2021b; HRC, 2013; HRW, 2016; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2017), as well as the lack of compassion (Docherty, 2012; HRC, 2013; HRW, 2016), given that such systems cannot be regarded as moral agents. From a consequentialist perspective, this absence of moral responsibility and empathy may increase the risk of unintended escalation and destructive violence (CSKR, 2021b; HRC, 2013; HRW, 2016; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2021a; UN, 2021b).

The absence of moral character, compassion, and empathy in autonomous systems is widely acknowledged in academic literature (Asaro, 2012; Wagner, 2014). However, some scholars argue that the safety of just combatants — potentially enhanced through automation — may, in certain cases, take precedence over the preservation of “humanity” in killing (Burri, 2018; McMahan, 2006), particularly if future technological developments were capable of embedding forms of artificial emotional responsiveness into machines (Lim, 2019).

Unpredictability and Incomprehensibility

Given their full autonomy, LAWS are also criticized — from both deontological and consequentialist perspectives — for the unpredictability of their decisions (CSKR, 2021b; HRC, 2013; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2014; UN, 2016; UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a; UN, 2024b) and for the potential incomprehensibility of their internal mechanisms to human operators (CSKR, 2021b; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2024b). These concerns are particularly acute in the fluid, complex, and open-ended contexts of armed conflict (CSKR, 2013; CSKR, 2021b; HRC, 2013; UN, 2014; UN, 2021a). Unpredictability is regarded as morally objectionable in itself

(Sharkey, 2016), as well as dangerous in its potentially catastrophic consequences, which may stem not from human error but from system malfunction and unforeseeable interactions (HRW, 2016; Rosendorf et al., 2022).

Moreover, the problems of unpredictability and “uninterpretability” (Spazian et al., 2021) are expected to intensify with advances in machine learning (CSKR, 2021b; Docherty, 2012; ICRC, 2021; UN, 2016) and with the development of autonomous collective intelligence in swarm systems (Docherty, 2012). While some scholars argue that predictability and comprehensibility can be enhanced through strict technical reliability standards during system development (Müller, 2016), even more permissive academic perspectives acknowledge the risks associated with future machine learning developments (Acheson, 2020b; Kallenborn, 2020; UNDP, 2022).

Accountability Gap and Responsibility

Reports from UN debates further emphasize the accountability gap that LAWS may create, particularly in light of their lack of moral agency and the potential difficulty of tracing decision-making processes (CSKR, 2013; CSKR, 2021b; Docherty, 2012; HRC, 2013; HRW, 2016; UN, 2014; UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a; UN, 2021b; UN, 2024b; UN, 2024c). The absence of clear legal responsibility for lethal errors or violations of IHL is viewed as deontologically troubling and consequentially harmful, as it may undermine the authority and enforceability of IHL in addressing unaccounted-for war crimes (Docherty, 2012; HRC, 2013; UN, 2017; UN, 2021a; UN, 2022; UN, 2024b).

Academic commentators likewise argue that if a weapon’s design renders meaningful responsibility and accountability for its consequences unattainable, its use should be considered both unethical and unlawful (Docherty, 2015; Sparrow, 2007; Wagner, 2014). However, opposing views maintain that responsibility can always be attributed to human actors involved in the design, deployment, or command chain — and in some cases even to machines themselves

when malfunctions occur (Burri, 2018). Some further suggest that LAWS may enable more accurate data collection regarding battle-field conduct, potentially improving the attribution of responsibility and even reducing the incidence of war crimes (Müller, 2016).

Immediate Threat to Life

Finally, certain reports highlight the morally significant issue of the “lack of mortality” (HRC, 2013, p. 17) or the incapacity of LAWS to experience or appreciate an “immediate threat to life” (UN, 2016, p. 10). Although this characteristic is shared with other unmanned systems, including remotely operated ones, LAWS arguably intensify the concern. Not only would human combatants face weapons or adversaries incapable of experiencing vulnerability or death, but the systems making lethal decisions would themselves be devoid of any sense of existential risk. This constitutes a novel feature with both deontological implications and morally consequential effects.

Exacerbated Moral Risks Shared with Unmanned Systems

Lower Threshold for Armed Conflict

The final cluster of moral concerns identified in these reports relates to the broader risks that LAWS may pose to the dynamics of armed conflict. Many of these risks are already associated with partially autonomous or remotely operated unmanned systems but are considered significantly intensified in the case of fully autonomous weapons. Although some reports acknowledge that such systems might reduce the “human costs of war” (Docherty, 2012, p. 4) — at least for technologically advanced actors — they express concern that lowering the human and political costs of warfare would reduce the threshold for resorting to armed conflict (CSKR, 2013; CSKR, 2021b; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a). If the use of force becomes less costly in terms of soldiers’ lives and domestic political repercussions, armed violence may become easier to initiate and, therefore, more likely (Docherty, 2012; Müller, 2016; Singer, 2009).

Shifting the Burden of War from Combatants to Civilians

Civil society organizations, in particular, warn that reducing the presence of human combatants on the battlefield could “shift the burden of war from combatants to civilians” (CSKR, 2021b, para. 16; Docherty, 2012, p. 4). Such a development would be normatively troubling under IHL and morally problematic more broadly, as some scholars argue (Brunet et al., 2021), since it risks increasing civilian exposure to harm while insulating decision-makers and operators from direct danger.

Arms Races and Escalation

Both UN reports and civil society submissions highlight the dangers of arms races and unintended international escalation that could result from the unregulated development and deployment of LAWS (CSKR, 2013; CSKR, 2021b; UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019). Academic analyses similarly caution that these risks, combined with a lowered threshold for armed conflict, could intensify the disruption of human welfare and environmental stability (Arkin et al., 2019; Asaro, 2012).

Cyberattacks and Non-State Actors

UN reports additionally emphasize the risks of proliferation, including the potential acquisition of LAWS by terrorist groups or other non-state actors (UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a; UN, 2021b), as well as the vulnerabilities posed by cyberattacks (UN, 2014; UN, 2017; UN, 2018; UN, 2019; UN, 2021a; UN, 2021b). The prospect of hacking, system manipulation, or unauthorized use amplifies concerns about the destabilizing effects of these technologies.

Opposing academic perspectives, however, counterbalance these risks with what they regard as potentially broader benefits. They argue that LAWS could reduce the physical human costs of war (Müller, 2016), as well as the “mental and emotional harm” experi-

enced by human combatants tasked with killing (Burri, 2018, p. 182). Furthermore, they maintain that increasing technical precision could reduce collateral damage as autonomous systems become more clinically effective in target selection (Young, 2021). For some scholars, these anticipated benefits are sufficient not only to resist a ban but to oppose it even on moral grounds (Arkin, 2017).

Critical Discussion and Interpretation

This study has brought together the diverse — deontological and consequentialist — concerns raised by LAWS in order to conduct a comprehensive assessment of their three principal moral and normative dimensions: first, the inherent obstacles that may prevent LAWS from complying with traditional IHL and IHRL principles; second, the claim that they generate unprecedented moral issues beyond the scope of IHL; and third, their intensification of moral risks — many of them consequentialist in nature — already associated with earlier unmanned weapons systems. Across all three dimensions, the requirement for some form of human control, supervision, or judgment consistently emerges as central.

Building on the structured presentation of the findings, this section offers a critical interpretation aimed at identifying possible regulatory pathways. On the basis of the evidence gathered, the argument that LAWS may be capable of complying with IHL principles and their humanitarian foundations appears significantly weakened, as many of the moral concerns identified seem difficult to reconcile with full IHL compliance. At the same time, the claims that LAWS introduce unprecedented transformations and far-reaching challenges are strongly supported by both academic and institutional debates, which express concern not only about IHL compliance but also about broader moral threats and risks that extend beyond its framework.

Given the breadth and depth of the moral concerns articulated, designing appropriate regulatory responses for LAWS is far from straightforward. Some proposals advocate a “two-tier approach” (UN, 2024b, p. 6), distinguishing between elements deemed inher-

ently incompatible with IHL — which should be prohibited — and those capable of compliance, which should be subject to strict regulation. According to the ICRC (2021), such regulation could include limitations on target types; restrictions on duration, geographical scope, and scale of use; constraints on contexts of deployment; and clear requirements for human–machine interaction.

Among these elements, the latter — human–machine interaction — is widely regarded as the most critical. UN discussions repeatedly emphasize the necessity of meaningful, “context-appropriate” (UN, 2025, p. 5) human control or supervision over critical functions. Yet uncertainty remains as to whether such control should be understood as an implicit requirement under existing IHL (UN, 2021a) or as a complementary “new legally binding provision” (UN, 2018, p. 20) or “organizing principle” (Barbé & Badell, 2020, p. 138). For some scholars, Meaningful Human Control (MHC) constitutes both a fundamental ethical requirement for any weapon and the primary solution to the ethical dilemmas and risks posed by LAWS (Amoroso & Tamburrini, 2020).

There appears to be broad consensus that regulation of critical lethal functions is necessary to ensure some degree of human control or supervision. At the same time, there is notable resistance to what has been described as a “double ban” (Anderberg et al., 1992, p. 295) on both the means and methods of warfare (Arkin et al., 2019), particularly given claims that LAWS may significantly outperform humans in certain functions or operations in morally clear contexts (Burri, 2018).

Fundamentally, many participants in the debate seem to seek a constructive partnership between human and machine capacities (Sharkey, 2016). This aspiration has fueled calls to modernize arms control frameworks (Paoli et al., 2020) and to rethink aspects of international law (Roumate, 2021) in order to address forthcoming non-human developments more effectively. The aim is not to dilute normative standards in response to technological change, but rather to strengthen them and prevent adaptation to declining ethical thresholds (Asaro, 2012; Sullins, 2013). In institutional forums, this has translated into demands for effective MHC and sustained IHL

compliance throughout the entire lifecycle of such systems (CSKR, 2021a; UN, 2024a), in accordance with Article 36 weapons review obligations (UN, 1977). Some have even called for pre-development assurances that human-controlled LAWS would demonstrably outperform human actors in complying with IHL (Amoroso & Tamburrini, 2020; Arkin et al., 2019).

The diversity and tension within these debates invite several critical reflections. In certain instances, it is not entirely clear whether the moral — particularly deontological — objections raised are directed specifically at lethal autonomous weapons or at automated decision-making systems more broadly. Institutional and academic analyses alike have noted limited social acceptance of autonomous weapons and algorithmic control (Arkin, 2009; Rosendorf et al., 2022; UN, 2014), as well as intuitive moral rejection of lethal LAWS (Skerker et al., 2020). There appears to be a broader societal unease with the dehumanization of killing (Asaro, 2012), arguably rooted in a “veil of ignorance” perspective (Rawls, 1972, p. 11), though attitudes may shift when the prospect of protecting one’s own forces is introduced (Horowitz, 2016).

Some perspectives go further, expressing an overarching deontological rejection of robotic warfare, of both the absurdity and the dehumanization of automated killing and of the inhumane and undignified deaths it produces. From this standpoint, war is already a morally compromised political instrument, and robotics compounds this dishonor. Such critiques reject not only asymmetric automated warfare — seen as violating moral equality among combatants (McMahan, 2006; Skerker et al., 2020) — but also hypothetical robot-versus-robot conflicts, which risk normalizing war as an automated yet still destructive industrial process (Korać, 2018).

More broadly, it is evident that all innovations in weaponry, including those designed to enhance compliance with IHL, raise moral dilemmas because their ultimate purpose remains lethal. Contemporary war ethics, particularly in the context of LAWS, increasingly revolve around the elusive ideal of absolute precision (Zehfuss, 2011) and improved compliance, potentially diverting

attention from the traditional normative objective of restricting and humanizing war (Hirst, 2002; Rappert, 2013). Indeed, recent technological developments do not necessarily appear motivated by a genuine aspiration to make warfare more humane or just (Sullins, 2013; Wagner, 2014; Zehfuss, 2011). Rather, the automation of killing often seems driven by strategic and technical imperatives — avoiding “baroque” inefficiencies (Kaldor, 1982) and enhancing performance in terms of effectiveness, that is, lethality (Schwarz, 2018; Wagner, 2014).

Ultimately, a deeper dilemma arises. While regulation is practically indispensable, it may appear conceptually paradoxical to regulate weapons when what is being regulated — war itself — can be understood as inherently “absurd” (Camus, 1942). Unless the objective is to render war obsolete (Beebe & Kaldor, 2010), arms control may inadvertently legitimize the violence it seeks to constrain (Ferl, 2024). Regulation implicitly acknowledges that killing can be permissible under certain conditions (Zehfuss, 2011), thereby contributing to the normalization of war (Krishnan, 2009). In contrast, in light of the dangers of future large-scale conflicts, some argue that war should be approached with profound moral caution and regarded as fundamentally deplorable (Lo, 2015), a practice that humanity ought ultimately to reject as a legitimate means of pursuing political ends.

Conclusion

This study has provided a comprehensive account of the moral and normative considerations surrounding LAWS, their deployment, and their regulation. Drawing on a necessarily limited yet systematic analysis of reports produced within UN institutional debates — including contributions from the United Nations, the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots (CSKR), Human Rights Watch (HRW), and the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) — the study has undertaken an informed examination and critical discussion of the principal moral arguments, alongside opposing perspectives. It concludes that LAWS not only generate significant challenges with

respect to compliance with IHL, but also raise unprecedented moral concerns that extend beyond its framework, while intensifying moral risks already associated with other unmanned systems. Accordingly, any meaningful discussion of their regulation — particularly through the lens of meaningful human control — must rest on a comprehensive and integrative analysis of all three dimensions of moral concern identified in this study.

Given the unprecedented transformations introduced by these technologies — transformations that are likely to deepen in the future — a reconsideration of the prevailing theoretical framework may be warranted. Debate on LAWS has largely focused on whether new weapons can attain legitimacy or ethical acceptability by improving compliance with IHL, enhancing precision, and reducing human costs. If this remains the dominant paradigm, then at a minimum the objective should be to ensure a level of meaningful human control capable of fostering innovative human-machine partnerships that are more humanitarian than either humans or machines operating alone (Sharkey, 2016).

Yet greater precision does not necessarily equate to greater ethicality, and humanity may have an indispensable role to play in moral decision-making. Even if technological improvements enhance compliance with legal standards, the core question should not center solely on the sophistication of weapons systems or their capacity to minimize civilian harm. Future debates and policy responses should move beyond technological adjustments (Zehfuss, 2011) and reactive normative adaptations designed merely to maintain formal adherence to IHL. Instead, they should engage in deeper ethical and political reflection on what morality and justice demand in relation to technological military innovation (McMahan, 2006). The future international order requires sustained and serious deliberation not only on the regulation of emerging weapons technologies, but also on the moral foundations of warfare itself.

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Corresponding Author Biography

Jan Falgueras-Riu (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-5456-7490>) holds a B.A. in Philosophy, Politics and Economics from Universitat Pompeu Fabra, completed in collaboration with the universities of the Alianza 4 Universidades (UPF, UAB, UAM, and UC3M). He pursued his undergraduate studies in both Barcelona and Madrid and spent an Erasmus year at the University of Warwick, where he developed a strong interest in international affairs. He subsequently earned an M.A. in International Relations, Security and Development from the Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona, graduating top of his class and serving as class representative. Alongside his studies, he held several professional positions, most recently working as a Research

Assistant on European Union-funded projects at the Universitat de Barcelona, where he contributed to research and publications on youth engagement in European politics. In 2025, he was awarded a scholarship to pursue an M.Sc. in Theory and History of International Relations at the London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE).

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Human Rights and the United Nations in the Geopolitics of the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970)

Oluchukwu Ignatus Onianwa

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Abstract

How did human rights advocacy during the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970) interact with great-power interests and African regional diplomacy to shape whether—and how—the United Nations considered debating or intervening in the Nigeria–Biafra conflict? The aim of this article is to examine the attitudes of the great powers and African states toward the campaign to place the Nigerian Civil War on the agenda of the United Nations. To address this question, the study employs a descriptive case study method, drawing primary sources, including archival materials obtained from The National Archives in Kew, London, and the archives at the United Nations Headquarters in New York, as well as the secondary literature. Our analysis reveals that human rights advocacy generated sustained pressure—through petitions, parliamentary debates, and diplomatic messaging—to place the Nigeria–Biafra war on the UN agenda, whereas great-power calculations produced uneven support (e.g., episodic initiatives from Canada and France versus British resistance),

keeping the issue politically contested rather than institutionally actionable. African regional diplomacy, led by the Organization of African Unity (OAU), prioritized sovereignty and territorial integrity and urged UN members to avoid steps that could “internationalize” secession, a stance echoed by many African delegations even when they voiced humanitarian concern in General Assembly debates. As a result, the UN Secretariat under U Thant deferred to the OAU framework and treated the conflict as an internal matter, limiting UN engagement largely to humanitarian relief while avoiding formal debate or coercive intervention at the Security Council or General Assembly.

Keywords

African geopolitics; great-power politics; human rights advocacy; Nigerian civil war; United Nations

Introduction

Globally, conflicts become human rights issues once human lives are threatened by the military operations that accompany them. If human rights are a serious concern in everyday life, they become even more critical during wartime. The Nigerian Civil War became a focal point of human rights campaigns that called for political and diplomatic intervention by the United Nations. These efforts were spearheaded by human rights groups, non-governmental organizations, churches, and national governments in Europe and North America. The civil war inspired numerous human rights organizations that believed in the ideal of a just world (Götz, 2024), emphasizing liberty and a broader commitment to humanitarian action.

The United Nations was widely regarded as the only multilateral body capable of resolving the Nigeria–Biafra crisis, particularly after the conflict extended beyond military confrontation to encompass grave human rights concerns. Beginning in July 1967, the United Nations received a series of communications from around the world urging that the Nigerian–Biafran conflict be discussed at both the General Assembly and the Security Council. On 19 July 1967, while the Consultative Committee of the Organization of African Unity

(OAU) was meeting in Kinshasa to deliberate on the civil war, the Special Representative of the Republic of Biafra in the United States and Canada, Nwonye Otue, wrote an official letter to the UN Secretary-General, U Thant. In the letter, he expressed concern over what he described as the global “wait-and-see” attitude toward the Nigeria–Biafra War and the apparent disregard for the suffering and hardship endured by civilians in the war zone (Nwonye, 1967).

The year 1968 witnessed intense human rights campaigns led by prominent individuals and international human rights organizations in major world capitals such as London, Washington, DC, Lisbon, and Paris. These campaigns protested global inaction regarding the civil war and called for an UN-backed resolution on the conflict (Achebe, 2012). Petitions were presented and communiqués issued to the UN Secretary-General, U Thant, during the war. Questions were raised about what the United Nations was doing to ensure the adequate protection of civilian lives and property in the face of military confrontation and massacres. As Albert S. Balima argued, “it seems that more silence from the UN would be harmful and now is the time that the United Nations voice should be heard for it is its duty to solve this problem otherwise, if the UN has to be but a rostrum for the third world claims, it would not have fulfilled its real mission” (Balima, 1968). The movement acquired a geopolitical dimension when some UN member states joined the call for UN intervention, while major great powers resisted efforts to have the war formally debated at the United Nations. This became a highly significant episode in shaping the international politics of the civil war.

The aim of this article is to examine the attitudes of the great powers and African states toward the campaign to place the Nigerian Civil War on the agenda of the United Nations. While the study discusses the responses of both the Biafran and Nigerian governments to proposals for debating the conflict, it also analyzes the reaction of the United Nations to efforts aimed at bringing the war before the General Assembly and the Security Council. The study draws on primary sources, including archival materials obtained from The National Archives in Kew, London, and the

archives at the United Nations Headquarters in New York. It also makes use of secondary sources from the Kenneth Dike Library at the University of Ibadan, as well as relevant internet sources.

This study is structured around the following research question: How did human rights advocacy during the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970) interact with great-power interests and African regional diplomacy to shape whether—and how—the United Nations considered debating or intervening in the Nigeria–Biafra conflict? To address this question, the study employs a descriptive case study method, “one that is focused and detailed in which proportions and questions about a phenomenon are carefully scrutinized and articulated at the outset” (Tobin, 2010, p. 288). The findings reveal that the Nigeria–Biafra experience contributed to the emergence of a human rights consciousness anchored in international consensus to address humanitarian catastrophes wherever they occur. The United Nations was widely perceived as the only multilateral institution capable of resolving the Nigeria–Biafra crisis, especially once the conflict had escalated beyond military confrontation to encompass serious human rights violations. The scale of human suffering witnessed during the war was such that no responsible organization, particularly the United Nations, was expected to remain idle. The UN was therefore seen as duty-bound to work actively, in collaboration with regional organizations, to address the crisis. It was proposed that the General Assembly could adopt a resolution recognizing the international humanitarian obligations arising from the Nigerian situation and, under the authority of the UN Charter, mandate the Secretary-General to use his good offices and all available resources to expedite the achievement of a peaceful settlement between the parties to the conflict. National governments were expected to support these efforts.

However, the United Nations ultimately took the position that the conflict constituted an internal affair and that it should refrain from direct involvement. The OAU had already established a Consultative Committee to address the Nigerian crisis, composed of the leaders of Niger, Liberia, Cameroon, Congo-Kinshasa, Ghana, and Ethiopia. Despite sustained campaigns to place the matter on

the UN agenda, the great powers were strongly influenced by the positions of both the UN Secretary-General and the OAU. Given that the issue concerned civil war and secession, many African states preferred to keep the matter within an African framework and discouraged recourse to the General Assembly, as the Secretary-General observed.

The first section of this study examines how certain Western nations attempted to place the Nigerian Civil War on the official agenda of the United Nations. The second section analyzes the reactions of African states during debates at the United Nations General Assembly. The third section explores the responses and attitudes of the United Nations to global calls for UN-backed discussions of the civil war.

The United Nations, Human Rights, and the Geopolitics of the Civil War

The campaign for a United Nations intervention in the Nigerian Civil War assumed a geopolitical dimension when national governments—particularly in Europe, North America, and Africa—began facing mounting pressure from their citizens and advocacy groups to sponsor debates on the conflict at the UN General Assembly or Security Council. In the United States, members of Congress and various pressure groups exerted significant pressure on the government to persuade UN Secretary-General U Thant to mediate in the civil war (Wilford, 1968).

The call for urgent debate at the United Nations was brought before the U.S. House of Representatives in Washington, DC, by several congressmen who felt they could no longer remain passive as conditions in Nigeria and Biafra deteriorated. On 4 December 1967, Congressman Benjamin Resnick, a New York Democrat and known supporter of Biafra, together with eight other congressmen—Brown of California, Conyers, Farbstein, Gray, Halpern, Hawkins, Mizer, and Rees—submitted a resolution. The resolution, which was referred to the House Committee on Foreign Affairs, appealed to the United Nations and other appropriate bodies to

take measures, including the dispatch of impartial observers, to protect civilian lives in the conflict zone (Owen, 1967).

Similarly, on 26 July 1968, Senator Eugene J. McCarthy, a Democratic presidential candidate and former Chairman of the African Affairs Subcommittee of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, issued a statement at his campaign headquarters in Washington, DC. He urged the U.S. government to bring a resolution before the United Nations calling for an air and sea lift of food supplies to Biafra, where the civil war had resulted in widespread starvation and civilian deaths. He argued that if the United Nations proved reluctant to act, the United States should take the initiative (United States of America Government, 1968).

The U.S. government began to pay closer attention to domestic calls for UN intervention when Senator Edward Kennedy delivered his well-known speech on the Nigerian Civil War before Congress on 23 September 1968. In the speech, he urged President Richard Nixon to support efforts to place the conflict on the agenda of the UN General Assembly. Other members of Congress who supported UN action included Senators Russell, Mansfield, Lausche, Symington, Dodd, Proxmire, Charles E. Goodell, and John Dow of New York. Only Senator Pearson expressed the view that African state delegates at the UN General Assembly preferred to have the matter resolved within an African framework rather than through UN intervention (United States Congressional Record—Senate, 24-24 September 1968; United States Congressional Record, 31 July & 25 September 1968; Markpress News Feature Service, 1969). This position aligned with the official U.S. government stance that the civil war was primarily a local and African issue, and that external intervention would have limited prospects of success (United States Department of State, 2005a, 2005b).

Canada was another country that considered presenting the Nigerian Civil War at the United Nations, largely in response to domestic pressure arising from concern over the humanitarian catastrophe in Biafra and Nigeria. On 17 September 1968, the Canadian Minister of External Affairs, Mitchell Sharp, declared before Parliament that he had considered whether Canada should refer the

humanitarian aspects of the conflict to the UN (Rogers, 1969). He noted that he and Prime Minister Pierre Trudeau were devoting more attention to the Biafra issue than to any other matter at the time (Rogers, 1969). For Biafran officials, the Canadian government's willingness to raise the issue at the UN was seen as a positive diplomatic development, as noted by the Biafran Commissioner for Foreign Affairs, Matthew Mbu, on 18 September 1968, and by General Ojukwu during the October 1968 visit of Canadian Member of Parliament Stephen Lewis to Biafra (Markpress News Feature Service, 1968a, 1968b, 1968c).

However, the Nigerian government was displeased with Canada's position. Consequently, on 20 September 1968, a scheduled meeting between General Yakubu Gowon and a Canadian observer team led by General Alexandra—initially planned for 21 September—was cancelled. The Canadian High Commissioner in Nigeria was also summoned for questioning. It required the intervention of the Canadian Representative at the UN, Ignatieff (1968), to prevent further escalation, especially as Secretary-General U Thant himself was not enthusiastic about bringing the matter before the General Assembly or Security Council (United Kingdom Mission to the United Nations, 1968).

The French government adopted a strong position in favor of presenting the Nigerian Civil War at the United Nations following its declaration of 31 July 1968. In that statement, the French Secretary of State for Information, M. Joël Le Theule, emphasized that the conflict should be resolved on the basis of the right to self-determination and through appropriate international procedures. General Charles de Gaulle further stated that “only a political solution which took into account the rights of the Biafran people to self-determination could resolve the Nigerian–Biafran question” (British Embassy Paris, 1968). Initially, France appeared primarily concerned with the humanitarian dimension of the war, advocating an arms embargo on both sides to reduce loss of life and protect civilians (Fafowora, 1990).

On 7 October 1968, French Foreign Minister Michel Debré brought the Biafran issue before the UN General Assembly, deliv-

ering a speech in which he argued that any resolution of the war must be consistent with the principle of self-determination enshrined in the UN Charter. His remarks suggested that France supported Biafran independence. This stance reflected both De Gaulle's strategic calculation that Biafra had developed a distinct national consciousness and his desire to prevent a large Anglophone federation from dominating smaller Francophone states in West Africa (British Embassy Paris, 1968).

At a meeting of the French Foreign Affairs Committee of the National Assembly on 12 October 1968, Debré reiterated that peaceful negotiations would be impossible unless Biafra's right to self-determination was recognized, particularly by the United Nations (British Embassy Paris, 1968). During a meeting in New York on the same day, Debré told Secretary-General U Thant that a community of twelve million people had the right to determine its own future, arguing that Biafra differed significantly from the rest of Nigeria in terms of race, religion, and culture. U Thant, however, responded that he could not endorse secession, either as Secretary-General or in any other capacity. He warned that endorsing secession would jeopardize African unity and potentially lead to chaos (Foreign Office, 1968).

In a conversation with U.S. Secretary of State William Rogers in Washington, DC, on 1 March 1969, Debré rejected the argument that the General Assembly lacked competence to address the Biafra question due to the existence of the OAU. He argued that if continental organizations rendered the UN incompetent in such matters, the UN would soon retain jurisdiction only over the oceans and seas. Secretary Rogers replied that both governments were aware that the OAU did not consider UN involvement appropriate and had themselves resisted such intervention. Although the United States had hoped the UN might play a constructive role, it did not see a viable path forward (United States Department of State, 2005a, 2005b).

On 8 August 1969, French official Beaumarchais informed U.S. National Security Adviser Henry Kissinger that President Georges Pompidou had observed that while the United Nations devoted

considerable time to issues such as Rhodesia, it failed to examine the Nigerian–Biafra crisis. In response, it was argued that the Nigerian conflict was a political matter in which many African states supported the Federal Military Government and were reluctant to have it debated at the UN. On 5 February 1969, the Italian Parliament passed a motion declaring the Nigeria–Biafra conflict an international matter under the United Nations Convention of 9 December 1948. The motion, introduced by Honourable Fracanzani, asserted that only UN intervention could achieve a peaceful resolution, given the moral, political, and legal grounds for such action (Markpress News Feature Service, 1969). At the 354th Ministerial Meeting of the Council of the Western European Union, held in Rome on 21–22 October 1968, the Italian Secretary for Foreign Affairs, S.E. M.F. Malfatti, urged member states to raise the issue at the United Nations, citing strong public and parliamentary concern in Italy (Walter, 1968).

The Swedish government, on humanitarian grounds, also sought to present the conflict at the United Nations. This proposal followed discussions in Stockholm between Swedish officials, representatives of the International Committee of the Red Cross, and Biafran authorities. The initiative was prompted by a report on the humanitarian catastrophe in Biafra sent to Prime Minister Tage Erlander by Commander Carl Gustaf von Rosen. However, when Von Rosen presented the issue to Secretary-General U Thant in New York, the latter maintained that the matter was an internal Nigerian issue and declined to intervene.

Britain, despite acknowledging the humanitarian dimensions of the conflict, was disinclined to support debate of the Nigerian Civil War at the United Nations. Gray Blank (2013) has argued that the war was a major foreign policy concern for the Harold Wilson government, Parliament, and Britain as a whole. Given Britain's policy of supporting the Federal Nigerian government, it was not in its interest to refer the conflict to the UN in a manner that might undermine British strategic interests. This reasoning underpinned Britain's opposition to Canadian and French diplomatic initiatives calling for UN debate. British officials relied on the principle that

the United Nations should not intervene in matters essentially within the domestic jurisdiction of a member state. Although the UN engaged in humanitarian operations through agencies such as UNICEF, the UK avoided supporting calls for political debate at the UN, as this would contradict the Federal Government's claim that the war was an internal matter (Moberly, 1968). Britain therefore relied on the Nigerian Federal Government to take steps to prevent the inscription of the conflict on the agenda of the General Assembly or Security Council.

Nearly all countries that considered raising the issue at the United Nations were diplomatically engaged by British officials in an effort to discourage such initiatives. According to Williams Ajibola, governments including NATO allies such as the Netherlands, Scandinavian countries, the Republic of Ireland, and Canada contemplated bringing the matter before the UN, but Britain intervened after protests from the Federal Government of Nigeria, and the plans were abandoned (Ajibola, 1978). The United Kingdom's Diplomatic Mission to the UN in New York also consulted African delegates—including some not unsympathetic to the Biafran cause—regarding the possibility of debate. They found that African states were generally unwilling to have the matter raised at the UN, particularly while the OAU was actively addressing it through various peace summits.

Similarly, the Nigerian government was encouraged to instruct its diplomats in New York to lobby other UN member states to abandon any proposed resolutions. The British government handled the issue with caution, seeking to avoid confrontation at the United Nations between Western countries and African states, whose views had been clearly articulated through the OAU. Nevertheless, this did not prevent UN member states from expressing their views on the conflict during General Assembly debates. Evidence indicates that numerous countries, including African states, spoke about the tragic conflict in line with their respective national positions.

African States and United Nations General Assembly Debates During the Civil War

It is noteworthy that the controversy surrounding the formal inscription of the Nigerian Civil War on the United Nations agenda did not prevent African states from commenting on the conflict during General Assembly debates. For example, in his speech at the General Assembly session in October 1968, the Zambian Foreign Minister, Kamanga, stated that the conflict between Nigeria and Biafra deserved the attention of the world body. Zambia therefore believed that, in fulfillment of its universal mission and in accordance with Articles 11, 12, and 35 of the UN Charter, the United Nations should take up this critical issue and play a constructive role in bringing about lasting peace in Nigeria and Biafra (United Kingdom Mission to the United Nations, 1968).

The Algerian Foreign Minister, Abdelaziz Bouteflika, addressing the General Assembly, noted that while Algeria shared the humanitarian concerns arising from the conflict, it could not overlook the fact that the primary cause of the war was the attempted secession that had triggered the civil war in Nigeria. Although the humanitarian dimension deeply affected African states, he argued that it should not obscure the political reality: namely, a serious challenge to the unity and territorial integrity of an African state. Similarly, the Burundian Foreign Minister, Ntawurishira, observed that the war in Nigeria had caused numerous casualties and was deplored by his government. He warned that the success of secession anywhere in Africa, regardless of its motivation, would likely lead to the fragmentation of many African states.

In the same vein, the Foreign Minister of Congo-Brazzaville, M. Mondjo, declared that while his country condemned the war and its attendant horrors and injustices, it also condemned the secession, which he described as being cleverly inspired and encouraged from abroad with the aim of weakening the Federation of Nigeria. The representative of the Democratic Republic of Congo, Umba di Lutete, similarly emphasized that Nigeria's unity and territorial

integrity must be safeguarded in accordance with both the spirit of the UN Charter and relevant resolutions of the OAU.

The Ethiopian representative, Yifru, stated that Ethiopia believed the solution to the Nigerian crisis should essentially be left to Nigerians themselves, in line with the OAU Heads of State resolution of 16 September 1968, which called for an immediate cessation of hostilities based on the principle of a sovereign and united Nigeria. Abdoulaye, the representative of Guinea, maintained that the civil war must be resolved in accordance with the principles of the OAU Charter, which had been freely accepted by all African states. In his view, only full respect for the OAU Charter could prevent further wars in Africa. The Malian representative, Ousman Bâ, insisted that secession was condemned for objective reasons by Africans directly concerned, and that any contrary position would amount to direct support for imperialist monopolies and centrifugal forces hostile to the unity and independence of African states.

Laraki, the Moroccan representative, stated that his government had strongly hoped that the secessionist leaders, fully aware of the consequences of war, would cooperate with the Federal authorities to restore peace and unity within a framework of national integrity. Gaye, representing Senegal, argued that the internecine conflict extended beyond Nigeria and affected the future of Africa as a whole. He noted that African states had turned to the OAU to find a solution through the mission entrusted to the OAU Heads of State of Cameroon, Ethiopia, Ghana, Liberia, and Niger (United Kingdom Mission, 1969).

In contrast, the Tanzanian Foreign Minister, Mhando, told the General Assembly that it was inaccurate to describe the Nigerian Civil War as purely an African problem. Neither Nigeria nor Biafra manufactured the weapons used in the war, and the arms did not originate from Africa. A war fought on African soil with weapons supplied by superpowers could not be characterized as exclusively African. Tanzania therefore regarded the conflict as a human problem in which all nations represented in the General Assembly were implicated, particularly those supplying the instruments of mass destruction (Rogers, 1969).

Similarly, the Foreign Minister of Ivory Coast, Usher, informed the General Assembly that while it was commendable for Africa to show deep concern about the Nigerian Civil War, it was unacceptable to remain indifferent to a conflict that had claimed approximately two million lives according to some estimates. To protest what he described as an attitude unworthy of African humanism, Ivory Coast decided to abstain from supporting any resolutions concerning the conflict until it was brought to an end (Rogers, 1969).

The question of UN involvement in the civil war was a highly complex issue between the Nigerian and Biafran leaderships. The Biafran government was fully supportive of an international resolution of the conflict under the auspices of the United Nations. Biafran authorities believed that their right to existence could be secured if the UN assumed responsibility for the peace process and humanitarian operations, as UN involvement would further legitimize the establishment of the new republic (Caradon, 1968). They argued that it was paradoxical to consider only the OAU capable of resolving the crisis, while excluding the United Nations from playing any role. After all, the UN Charter is founded on principles of peace and security, the peaceful settlement of disputes, and respect for fundamental human rights, justice, and self-determination (Markpress News Feature Service, 1969). According to Ojukwu, “the UN should have intervened because of her obligation to protect life and property and the fundamental human rights entrenched in the Charter” (Markpress News Feature Service, 1970).

In a letter addressed to the President of the UN General Assembly, Angie Brooks, on 3 October 1968, Ojukwu expressed concern over the failure of national governments to prevent acts of genocide and to establish a humanitarian order grounded in equal rights and self-determination for the peoples of the region (Markpress News Feature Service, 1968a, 1968b, 1968c). He urged the General Assembly to invoke Article 8 of the Genocide Convention and take appropriate action under the Charter to prevent and suppress acts of genocide (Brucker, 2019).

Biafran representatives intensified their lobbying efforts at the

United Nations in an attempt to ensure that the world body gave due attention to the conflict and formally debated it. Professor Eni Njoku, leader of the Biafran Observer Group at the 24th Session of the General Assembly, wrote to Secretary-General U Thant on 14 October 1969, highlighting delegates' concerns over the tragic consequences of the war, particularly civilian suffering, hunger, and starvation. He also pointed to concerns about the open intervention of major powers, notably Britain and the Soviet Union, which, in his view, made it impossible for Africans to resolve the matter independently, as would otherwise have been expected. This intervention had contributed to the OAU's failure to resolve the conflict despite establishing an Ad Hoc Committee.

Despite being a member of the United Nations and a signatory to the UN Charter, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the Genocide Convention, and the 1949 Geneva Conventions (Markpress News Feature Service, 1968a, 1968b, 1968c), the Nigerian government opposed any UN-backed deliberation of the civil war. It maintained that its sovereignty and territorial integrity required that it retain full authority over its internal affairs without external interference. During a meeting with the British Representative to the United Nations, Lord Caradon, the Nigerian Ambassador, Ogbu, stated that "the Nigerian Government was most anxious that the problems of Nigeria should not be internationalized and consequently they were anxious to prevent any UN action in regard to Nigeria internal affairs. Thus, any UN action in regard to Nigeria would be unwelcome" (Caradon, 1968).

The Nigerian government also expressed diplomatic appreciation for the Secretary-General's position against placing the conflict on the agenda of either the General Assembly or the Security Council. On 15 February 1969, the Federal Commissioner for Transport, J. S. Tarka, issued a press release from the Federal Ministry of Information expressing gratitude for Secretary-General U Thant's supportive statement. Tarka had visited U Thant at UN Headquarters in New York on that date. Earlier, at a press conference, the Secretary-General had reaffirmed his support for the principle articulated by the Federal Military Government in its effort to

defeat Biafran secession (Federal Military Government of Nigeria, 1969).

The Federal Government's position was further articulated by the Federal Commissioner for External Affairs, Okoi Arikpo, who addressed the General Assembly in New York and reaffirmed Nigeria's indivisibility as a single political entity (Arikpo, 1969). While Biafra sought UN debate as a means of internationalizing what it framed as a human rights struggle with international legitimacy, the Federal Government resisted such efforts, fearing that UN deliberation could undermine its objective of preserving national unity and securing victory. Nigeria relied on the support of the OAU to oppose diplomatic initiatives at the UN and cautioned other member states against endorsing such proposals. In line with this stance, Secretary-General U Thant dismissed calls for UN debate as a futile exercise.

The United Nations Reaction to Human Rights Campaigners

In responding to the conflict, the United Nations was guided primarily by the resolutions adopted by the OAU at its meetings in Kinshasa and Algiers. The OAU urged all UN member states and all OAU members to refrain from any action likely to undermine the peace, unity, and territorial integrity of Nigeria. This directive significantly shaped the UN's response to human rights campaigners during the conflict, which was widely regarded as an African problem to be resolved by Africans (Adefuye, 1992). The UN recognized that political debate at the General Assembly or Security Council would be unproductive in the face of OAU opposition.

During a visit to Addis Ababa in 1969, Secretary-General U Thant suggested to Emperor Haile Selassie that the OAU should consider developing an imaginative constitutional arrangement—possibly in the form of a loose confederation between Nigeria and Biafra—with some degree of international involvement in implementing any settlement devised by the OAU (United Kingdom Mission to the United Nations, 1969).

Secretary-General U Thant adopted a non-interventionist posture and deferred to regional bodies such as the OAU. He granted the OAU considerable latitude in decision-making and implementation, thereby limiting the UN's role in discussing the Nigerian conflict. A UN initiative would have appeared to acknowledge the international character of the conflict, a step that would have been unacceptable to the Nigerian government, its allies, and the majority of UN member states that did not recognize Biafra (Achebe, 2012). U Thant's position was further reinforced by the fact that Biafra had not been officially recognized by the OAU. It was argued that recognition by the continental body should precede any endorsement by the UN or other multilateral institutions. As Bernard Odogwu observed, "Biafra, as far as the OAU was concerned, was non-existent... and moreover Biafra on her own part did not show enough cause why OAU decision should have been otherwise" (Odogwu, 1985).

This context strengthened the UN's resistance to formal debate on the issue and coincided with growing Federal opposition to internationalizing the conflict. As Chinua Achebe noted, a vacuum emerged in moral and humanitarian leadership at the UN, which allowed the Federal Military Government of Nigeria to operate without adequate international oversight (Achebe, 2012). Despite such criticism, Williams Ajibola (1978) argued that the UN's overall stance during the war amounted to a form of neutral pro-federalism, as the organization treated the situation as an internal Nigerian affair and continued to recognize the Federal Government as the legitimate authority. This position, in effect, contributed to Nigeria's diplomatic and military advantage in the civil war.

Conclusion

The harrowing accounts of human rights violations during the conflict opened a new frontier for human rights advocacy at the United Nations. Voluntary organizations and human rights activists converged on UN headquarters, demanding an end to the conflict and calling for urgent action on behalf of war victims, including

measures to prevent genocide in any form. Numerous petitions and communiqués were submitted to Secretary-General U Thant by organizations, governments, and prominent individuals worldwide during the civil war.

In the 1960s, as countries sought to play more active roles in global affairs and promote human rights internationally, the Nigerian Civil War presented an opportunity for states such as Canada to advance these foreign policy objectives. Issues that attracted significant attention within Canadian society included allegations of genocide, indiscriminate bombing and shooting of civilians, mass starvation, Biafra's claim to self-determination, and the supply of arms to both sides of the conflict. Canada maintained that all human beings, including those in war zones, were equal in dignity and worth. Accordingly, it viewed the United Nations as the only institution capable of organizing the humanitarian action necessary to protect civilian victims. By advocating accelerated UN deliberation on the conflict, Canada took active steps to draw global attention to the plight of those affected by the war.

Public opinion in the United States was similarly shaped by concerns over human rights and civilian protection. France's understanding of human rights centered on Biafra's claim to self-determination and sovereign freedom, which it believed could be realized through appropriate international legal procedures. Britain, however, strongly opposed discussing the war at the UN, fearing that such action would undermine its political and diplomatic objectives in support of the Federal Government.

Under Secretary-General U Thant, the United Nations adopted a cautious approach to calls for UN-backed intervention on human rights grounds. Nonetheless, the Nigerian Civil War contributed to the globalization of human rights discourse, anchored in an emerging international consensus that lives endangered by conflict must be protected wherever such crises occur. The war marked an important phase in the evolution of global humanitarian consciousness, grounded in liberal democratic principles that encourage public engagement with international issues and affirm the inherent value of human life.

The international community increasingly acknowledged its responsibility to alleviate human suffering in all its forms. Human suffering came to be regarded as a matter of global concern, demanding effective international action. Framing the Nigerian conflict as a struggle for justice and human rights influenced prominent figures in Western Europe and North America, who viewed the issue not merely as a legal or theoretical question of secession but as a fundamental matter of safeguarding basic human rights.

Human rights movements during the civil war were particularly active in North America and Western Europe. The existence of liberal democratic spaces in these societies facilitated the emergence of grassroots awareness and advocacy concerning the conflict. Humanitarian concerns were amplified by public opinion, including widespread discussion about the right of civilians to live and survive amidst war. There was a growing recognition that human beings possess an inherent right to life under all circumstances. In this context, the Nigerian Civil War became a powerful reminder of the need for global solidarity with populations trapped in conflict, reinforcing the imperative to defend human dignity in times of war.

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Corresponding Author Biography

Oluchukwu Ignatus Onianwa (ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0006-6414-1007>), PhD, is a Lecturer and Coordinator in the Department of History, Strategic and International Studies, Faculty of Arts, Dennis Osadebay University, Anwai, Asaba, Delta State, Nigeria. He is a diplomatic and military historian whose research focuses primarily on the Nigerian Civil War and Biafran Studies. Dr. Onianwa is the author of several books, including *Britain's Injurious Peace Games in the Nigerian Civil War* (Academica Press, Washington, DC and London); *Once Upon a Time in Biafra: Memories, Foreign Visitations, and Life Experiences in the Nigerian Civil War, 1967–1970*; *Britain, the Royal Air Force, and Relief Flights to Biafra, 1968–1969*; *Oilfields in African Conflict: The Case of Biafra*; and *Battle of Biafra: British Intelligence and Diplomacy in the Nigerian Civil War, 1967–1970*.

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